

# FBI Field Agent Tradecraft Sourcebook – 1997

## Introduction

Role-playing an FBI special agent in 1997 requires understanding not just the laws and crimes, but the **tradecraft** – the practical, day-to-day methods and culture of Bureau field work. This sourcebook is a comprehensive guide to help a non-law enforcement player portray an FBI field agent authentically. We focus on how agents in the late 90s operated: how the FBI was structured, how cases started and progressed, investigative techniques, the forms and paperwork that drove bureaucracy, planning arrests and raids, cooperating with other agencies, preparing for court, internal culture, and the technology of the era. We intentionally **do not** dive deeply into forensics, detailed legal procedure, or federal statutes, as those are covered in other sourcebooks (e.g. **Forensics for FBI Agents (Late 1990s)** <sup>1</sup>, the **Phoenix Field Office Agent Legal Handbook (1997)** <sup>2</sup>, and the **Federal Crimes Reference Guide (1997)**). However, we will cross-reference those topics where relevant. By the end of this guide, you should be equipped to “walk the walk” and “talk the talk” like a real FBI agent circa 1997 – understanding not just what you do, but how and why you do it in that historical context.

**How to Use This Guide:** We’ve organized the material into logical sections, each with sub-topics. Throughout, you’ll find illustrative examples demonstrating how an FBI agent would handle various situations in 1997. These examples are historically accurate and tailored to a Phoenix Division agent where appropriate (since our hypothetical setting is Phoenix, Arizona), though the practices apply broadly to FBI field agents nationwide in that era. We use authentic FBI terminology and acronyms of the time, explaining them in plain language so you can incorporate them into dialogue or decisions in-game. If you need more detail on forensic techniques or legal specifics, check the referenced sourcebooks. Now, let’s start with how an FBI field office is organized and who answers to whom.

## FBI Field Office Structure and Hierarchy (Phoenix Division Example)

Every FBI field agent in 1997 operates within a clearly defined hierarchy. Understanding “who’s who” in a field office is key to knowing how decisions are made and where the player-character fits in the chain of command:

- **Special Agent in Charge (SAC):** The SAC is the head of a field office – in Phoenix Division this is the top boss. The SAC is responsible for all investigations and operations in their territory (for Phoenix, that’s the entire state of Arizona). They set priorities (aligned with FBI Headquarters guidance) and allocate resources. For example, by the 1990s the Phoenix Division’s priorities included white-collar crime, organized crime, and violent offenses <sup>3</sup>, and the SAC ensured squads were staffed accordingly. The SAC liaises with FBI Headquarters (FBIHQ) and local heads of other agencies. A Phoenix SAC in 1997 would know the U.S. Attorney, police chiefs, and agency heads in Arizona personally.

- **Assistant Special Agent in Charge (ASAC):** Larger field offices have one or more ASACs who report to the SAC. Phoenix, being a medium-large division, typically has at least one ASAC. The ASAC oversees broad program areas or branches – for example, one ASAC might oversee criminal programs (violent crime, organized crime, white-collar crime squads), while another might oversee national security programs (counterintelligence and terrorism squads). ASACs act as mid-level commanders, translating the SAC's priorities into action. Day-to-day, an ASAC in Phoenix might review sensitive case developments, approve certain undercover operations or informant recruitments, and handle administrative duties when the SAC is away.
- **Supervisory Special Agents (SSAs) and Squad Structure:** Field agents are organized into squads, each led by a Supervisory Special Agent. An SSA is essentially the team leader for a specific group of agents focusing on a particular crime program or task force. For example, Phoenix might have a **Violent Crime Squad**, a **White-Collar Crime Squad**, a **Drug/Gang Squad**, a **Criminal Enterprise (Organized Crime) Squad**, and perhaps a **Cyber Crime Squad** (the FBI's first dedicated computer crime squads were announced in 1997 <sup>4</sup>). Each squad's SSA assigns cases, guides investigations, approves reports, and ensures agents follow FBI policies. The SSA is the immediate boss a field agent deals with daily – they'll review your case files, ride along on high-priority operations, and mentor junior agents. In Phoenix, squads often have numeric designators (e.g., "Squad 1" might be violent crimes, "Squad 2" white-collar, etc.), but agents usually refer to them by mission (like "the Bank Robbery squad" or "the OC squad").
- **Special Agents (Field Agents):** These are the rank-and-file investigators – what your player character likely is. Special Agents (SAs) do the bulk of investigative work: interviewing witnesses, conducting surveillance, collecting evidence, executing arrests, etc. A new agent in 1997 would typically be assigned to a squad and work cases as part of a team. Within a case, usually one agent is designated the **"case agent"** (often the agent who opened the case or did the initial work). The case agent is the point person responsible for that investigation's overall progress and paperwork, even though many agents might assist. For instance, if you (as a Phoenix agent) open a bank robbery case, you'd be the case agent who coordinates everything – other agents might run leads for you, but you're expected to keep the overview and report to the SSA. Agents also might have specialty roles: e.g., one agent on a squad might be the **training coordinator**, another might handle **evidence custody** for the squad, etc., alongside their casework.
- **Support Personnel:** An FBI field office in 1997 isn't just agents. There are analysts (intelligence research specialists), surveillance specialists, language translators, administrative assistants, and evidence technicians. In Phoenix, where cross-border crime and cartels are factors, Spanish-speaking translators and analysts would be vital. The support staff have their own supervisors but integrate with agent squads. For example, an analyst might be assigned to the Violent Crime Squad to crunch crime stats or link cases, and a surveillance specialist might be part of a mobile stakeout team (surveillance specialists in the FBI are non-agent staff who are skilled at physical surveillance without blowing cover). While support personnel are not "in charge" of investigations, a smart agent relies on them for expertise – e.g. asking an analyst for a phone record analysis or getting a surveillance specialist to install a pole camera.
- **Resident Agencies (RAs):** Large FBI divisions like Phoenix have smaller satellite offices throughout their territory, known as Resident Agencies. An RA is typically staffed by a handful of agents (sometimes even just one or two in smaller towns), covering investigations in that region so agents

don't have to commute from the main field office for every lead. In 1997, the Phoenix Division had multiple RAs across Arizona – for instance, Tucson (the second-largest city in AZ) has a resident agency, likely led by a **Senior Resident Agent (SRA)** who is basically an SSA position but outstationed. Other RAs in places like Flagstaff, Yuma, Sierra Vista, Kingman, etc., each cover adjacent counties <sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup>. If your character is assigned to a Resident Agency, they might be more of a generalist (handling all types of federal crimes in that area) compared to Phoenix city agents who might be more specialized by squad. Communication between RAs and the main Phoenix office is constant – by phone, radio, or FBI's internal teletype – to coordinate cases. An RA agent still reports to the Phoenix SAC; they often have a lot of autonomy day-to-day due to distance, but they'll call in to the SSA in Phoenix for guidance or to request resources.

**Example – Chain of Command in Action:** Imagine you're a Special Agent on the Phoenix Violent Crime Squad in 1997. A kidnapping case comes up in rural Arizona. The call comes into Phoenix's duty line and is relayed to your squad. Your SSA tells you to take the lead as case agent. You might coordinate with the Senior Resident Agent in Flagstaff if the kidnapping occurred up north, since that RA is closer to the scene. You'll brief the ASAC or SAC if it's a high-profile case (e.g. child kidnapping draws HQ attention). As the investigation unfolds, you keep your SSA updated daily. When it's time to plan an arrest or large operation, the SAC might personally review the operational plan if it's sensitive (especially if it involves multiple agencies or potential hazards). In our scenario, say the kidnapper fled into the Navajo Nation – then the SAC will ensure you liaise with tribal police and maybe send additional agents from Phoenix. At the end of the case, if it's successful, the SAC might even mention it in their report to FBI Headquarters, highlighting the Phoenix Division's good work. Conversely, any major screw-up (like an accident on an arrest) will also go up the chain – accountability flows upward and back downward in the FBI.

Understanding this hierarchy helps you role-play the respect for authority and protocol. An agent doesn't freelance without informing the boss. In 1997's FBI culture, **following procedure and chain of command** was drilled into new agents (a reaction to scandals of prior decades <sup>7</sup>). In game terms, that means your agent character would habitually clear significant actions (opening a case, initiating a wiretap, going undercover, calling in SWAT) with their SSA or higher. They'd also use proper titles (calling their boss "Boss" or "Sir/Ma'am" or by title like "SSA Smith"). The hierarchy might feel bureaucratic, but it exists to ensure control and consistency – by 1997 the FBI had 56 field offices and about 10,000 personnel in the field <sup>8</sup>, so a clear structure was essential.

## How Cases Start, Are Managed, and Get Closed

FBI work is case-driven. A "case" is an investigation file with a unique number, focused on a suspected violation of federal law. We will walk through the life cycle of a case – from inception to closure – as it was in the late 90s. This will help you role-play the process an agent follows when handling investigations, ensuring you hit all the right notes of realism (like doing the paperwork at each stage, not just the car chases).

### Case Initiation: From Complaint to Official Case

Most cases begin with a **trigger event** – often called a **complaint**, "lead," or **information**. Common ways a case might start in Phoenix 1997 include: a member of the public reports a federal crime (e.g. a bank manager calls about a robbery – bank robberies are federal offenses), a state/local police agency requests

FBI help on something with federal interest, an FBI informant tips off about a crime, or an FBI agent uncovers something while working another investigation.

When something comes in, typically a **Complaint Form (FD-71)** is filled out to document it <sup>9</sup>. The FD-71 logs who the complainant is, what they're alleging, and any initial notes. For instance, if someone calls the Phoenix office about a person on the internet making bomb threats (yes, even in 1997, early internet cases existed), the duty agent would record it on an FD-71, capturing the facts and maybe doing a quick indices check (searching FBI records) to see if that person is already known to the Bureau. Simultaneously, an **FD-365 Summary of Complaint** might be prepared – essentially a condensed cover sheet for the complaint that helps a supervisor review the key points quickly <sup>10</sup>.

**Supervisory Approval and Case Number:** Once the initial complaint is logged, a supervisor (SSA) reviews it to decide if it warrants opening a case. The FBI doesn't open a formal case on every complaint – there needs to be at least some indication a federal crime may have occurred (this is called **predication**). If it's flimsy (like a vague rumor with no evidence), they might mark it for a **preliminary inquiry** or even close it out as unfounded. But assuming it's legit – say a credible witness saw a bank robber's car with out-of-state plates, suggesting federal jurisdiction – the SSA will approve opening a case. The case is then given a file number. FBI file numbers in 1997 have a specific format: a **classification code**, a **field office code**, and a **case sequence number**. For example, bank robbery cases fall under classification **091** (since 18 USC §2113 bank robbery is a common FBI crime) – a Phoenix bank robbery case file might be numbered **091A-PX-12345** (where "PX" or a numeric equivalent is Phoenix's office code, and 12345 is the sequential case ID) <sup>11</sup>. The opening of a new case is communicated to FBI Headquarters and possibly other field offices via an **FD-217 Notification of Bureau File Number** <sup>11</sup>, so everyone knows this subject or incident now has an active FBI case.

At this stage, the agent assigned becomes the **case agent**. In our example, you – the agent who took the complaint – might carry the case forward. One of the first things you'd likely do is an **indices check**: using an **Indices Search Slip (FD-160)** to query FBI central records for any mention of persons or entities involved <sup>12</sup>. This might turn up previous files (maybe the suspect was investigated before, or is in a criminal database). An FD-160 response gives you any file numbers that match, so you can pull those files for background. In 1997, these searches would be run through FBI's computer indices or by contacting the Records Management Division; the upcoming Integrated Automated Fingerprint Identification System (IAFIS) was still two years from launch <sup>13</sup>, but name-based index searches were routine.

**Opening Electronic Communication (EC):** Besides forms, the case agent usually writes an opening memorandum (often in the form of an **Electronic Communication** or older term "teletype" if urgent, FD-36) <sup>14</sup> to formally open the case in the Bureau's system. By 1997, the FBI had introduced a case management software called the **Automated Case Support (ACS)** system <sup>15</sup>. Agents would input basic case info into ACS (or have support staff do it) so it's officially logged. ACS was basically a big centralized database for case records – albeit a clunky green-screen system built on 1970s tech, considered a **legacy system even when it was new in 1995** <sup>16</sup>. Role-play wise, you might mention "entering the case into ACS" or "sending an FBIHQ electronic communication" to note that you're informing headquarters of a new case (especially for certain crimes, FBIHQ wants to know immediately; a bank robbery in 1997 would get a rapid teletype to HQ and other field offices describing the suspect and MO, in case it's a serial robber).

In summary, **to initiate a case** your agent character would: gather initial info (call or tip), document it on the proper form, seek supervisor approval, get a case number assigned, run initial background checks, and

formally log/open the file. Only then do you really start the active investigation. Skipping these steps would be “bad tradecraft” – an FBI agent always lays the paper trail from the start.

## Managing an Active Investigation

Once a case is open, the day-to-day work begins. As case agent, you plan and execute investigative steps. Key aspects of case management in the 90s FBI include **lead management**, **documentation**, **periodic reporting**, and **coordination** – we’ll break those down:

- **Leads and Lead Management:** A **lead** is any investigative task or clue that needs to be run down. Managing leads is a core skill. Leads can be **internal** (within your office) or **external** (for another office). For example, suppose in your Phoenix kidnapping case you learn the suspect’s vehicle is registered in California – you’d send a lead to the Los Angeles FBI office to do a background on the car’s owner or conduct a surveillance there. In 1997, leads were often sent as formal communications (like an EC or lead form) to the other field office, who would then assign one of their agents to cover it. If multiple leads are being worked, an agent often keeps a “lead control log.” There wasn’t fancy tracking software (ACS had a limited lead tracking function, but many agents still used paper logs or whiteboards). In the FBI **Case Status Form (FD-320)** you might note leads outstanding, so supervisors can see what’s in progress <sup>17</sup>. As case agent, you prioritize leads (triaging what’s urgent vs. what can wait). A **high-priority lead** might be immediately sending agents to interview a crucial witness or urgent fingerprint comparisons, whereas a **low-priority lead** might be a bank records subpoena that can take weeks. Good role-play would show your agent divvying up tasks: “I’ll handle the victim interview, and I’ll send a lead to our Tucson RA to canvass the bus station where the kidnapper was last seen.” Always remember to **follow up** – a common saying is “a case is only as good as the leads you chase.” An unaddressed lead could mean a bad guy slips away. In game terms, your GM might feed you many clues; acknowledging them and assigning them (to yourself, your squad mates, or other offices) shows you’re playing like an FBI agent.
- **Documentation and FD Forms:** The FBI runs on paper (or at least, in the 90s, on WordPerfect documents and printed memos). If it’s not documented, it didn’t happen. So for every action, there’s usually a form or report:
- Interviews get written up on **FD-302 (Report of Interview)** <sup>18</sup>. This is one of the most critical documents in FBI practice. After talking to someone – be it a witness, suspect, or informant – the agent writes a 302 detailing what was said (in narrative form, not Q&A transcript). In 1997 agents rarely tape-recorded interviews; they took notes by hand and later typed a 302. That means your agent character might carry a small notebook, scribble during conversations, then spend an evening typing it up. A 302 includes the date, time, location, who was present, and a summary of the information obtained. It’s written in a somewhat formal style (third person, e.g., “SA Jones interviewed John Doe who stated...”). If the interview is long, continuation pages **FD-302a** are used <sup>19</sup>.
- Physical evidence gets logged on evidence forms. An agent who seizes evidence will fill out an **FD-192 (Evidence Recovery Log)** and put items into appropriate containers (like the famous *FD-340 “1A” evidence envelope* for small items) <sup>20</sup>. Each piece gets an evidence number (often prefixed by the case number). Maintaining **chain of custody** is vital – if you pick up a ransom note, you immediately note the date/time and that it’s now in FBI custody, then if you pass it to the lab, an evidence technician or lab personnel will sign the chain custody form. The **Forensics for FBI Agents**

guide covers this in depth <sup>21</sup> <sup>22</sup> , but as a field tradecraft point: your agent character should be **fastidious** with evidence handling (wearing gloves, labeling bags, using the correct forms), or else risk evidence being inadmissible in court.

- Phone calls or miscellaneous investigative actions are often recorded in **memos or an FD-302 as well**. If it's important enough to mention to your boss or in court, write a memo. There's also an **FD-204 Investigative Report** format <sup>23</sup> , which is a narrative report that can summarize a bunch of investigative steps or findings in one document. Agents might file an FD-204 after a major phase of the case (e.g., "investigative report: results of three weeks of surveillance and intelligence gathered").
- **Maintaining the file:** All these documents – 302s, forms, teletypes (ECs), photos, evidence receipts – get serialized in the case file. A case file is typically a physical file folder (or a set of them if it's a big case) stored in the file room, with each document given a "serial" number in chronological order. Even with ACS in place, most agents in '97 still printed hard copies and assembled files. Support staff (file clerks) often helped file documents and could retrieve files for agents. An **FD-5 File Charge Out** form is used whenever a file is removed from the records room <sup>24</sup> – yes, even taking the file to your desk had to be logged, so it wouldn't get lost. This level of bureaucracy might sound tedious, but it's part of daily life. In-character, you might mention "I'll pull the file" or "I add the interview transcript to the 1A section of the file."
- **Periodic Case Reviews and Reporting:** FBI supervisors require updates, and FBIHQ often wants stats. By the 90s, it was common for field offices to submit a **quarterly case status report** for significant cases. The **FD-320 Case Status Form** we mentioned helps summarize open leads, subjects identified, and whether you're close to arrest or need more time <sup>17</sup> . Additionally, for long-running cases, you might prepare interim **Investigative Reports (FD-204)** to capture progress <sup>23</sup> . If you're about to move in on an arrest or you're closing the case, a **Prosecutive Summary (with an FD-272 cover)** may be written for the prosecutor, summarizing all the evidence and what charges you believe fit <sup>25</sup> . All these keep management in the loop. In role-play, you can reflect this by occasionally "checking in" with your SSA: e.g., "I brief SSA Garcia on what we have so far and ask if we should pivot our strategy." It shows your character isn't a lone wolf – they operate within the system.
- **Multi-Office Coordination:** If the case involves other FBI field offices (say our kidnapping suspect drove from Phoenix to Los Angeles), the Phoenix case agent is the **Office of Origin (OO)** and the other offices are **Offices of Assignment (OA)** for leads. As case agent, you'd send leads to the L.A. office and any other involved office. They will report back with memos or teletypes. It's your job to collate those into your case file. There's even an **FD-491 form (Transmittal to Office of Origin)** <sup>26</sup> that might accompany documents sent from one office back to you, ensuring proper chain and that nothing gets lost. This is important when role-playing national or multi-state cases: emphasize radioing or faxing information to other offices, awaiting their info in return, maybe hopping on phone calls with agents in those cities to compare notes. The FBI is one agency, but in the 90s it wasn't as centrally connected as today – communication was often person-to-person. A Phoenix agent might have to actually pick up a phone and call the agent in Los Angeles who's working your lead, to hash out details (email was around internally, but many senior agents still preferred phone or secure fax). The **teletype** culture was also strong: formal written messages (which by '97 were digital but still called "teletypes") would be sent for official record. In your game, you might say "I send a teletype to FBI Los Angeles and San Diego, providing the suspect's description and requesting any intel on similar cases <sup>27</sup> ," which is exactly what an FBI agent would do if, for example, a kidnapper might be part of a multi-state ring.

- **Example – Managing the Case:** Continuing our hypothetical Phoenix kidnapping case, you've opened the case and identified a suspect and vehicle. You now juggle multiple leads: One lead is to have an FBI artist create a sketch of the kidnapper based on a witness – you arrange that and document it. Another lead: check motels in the Phoenix area – you call local police for help (perhaps assigning a Phoenix Police detective on the Phoenix FBI Violent Crimes Task Force to canvass, since FBI often works joint with locals on kidnappings). You also need to inform the **National Crime Information Center (NCIC)** about the kidnapped child and suspect vehicle – NCIC is the federal database that local cops nationwide use to flag fugitives, stolen cars, etc., which the FBI maintains <sup>28</sup>. You coordinate with the FBI **National Center for the Analysis of Violent Crime (NCAVC)** at Quantico (in 1997, this would be calling the Behavioral Analysis Unit hotline) to get advice on child abduction patterns. All these actions are logged: you write a memo about the BAU consult, you keep a lead list (e.g. "Lead 5: check California vehicle records for suspect's van – sent to FBI LA"). As days go by, your SSA asks for a progress briefing. You present that you've covered 10 out of 12 leads, and plan a meeting with the AUSA (prosecutor) to discuss possible charges if the kidnapper is caught. Eventually, let's say the kidnapper is arrested in Nevada by local police – thanks to your NCIC alert – you dispatch a team to retrieve him (with a federal UFAP warrant – Unlawful Flight to Avoid Prosecution – since he fled state lines). After the dust settles, you prepare a **closing report**.

## Case Closure: When and How Investigations End

A case can't stay open forever. Closure happens under a few conditions: - **Solved with Arrest/Prosecution:** The ideal scenario – you identified the perpetrator, arrested them, and they've been indicted by a grand jury or otherwise charged. At that point, the investigative case file is largely complete, though agents might keep it open until trial is done. Once the trial is over (or a plea is entered), you'd close the case officially. Closing usually involves an **FD-515 Accomplishment Report** if applicable, capturing the stats: arrests, indictments, convictions, fines, etc. <sup>29</sup>. This feeds into FBI's statistics and helps justify resources. In 1997, the Phoenix office would tally such accomplishments for its yearly reports to FBIHQ and the Department of Justice. - **Closed Administratively (Unresolved):** Not all cases reach a happy conclusion. Sometimes, despite your efforts, you hit a dead end or the US Attorney's Office declines to prosecute (maybe insufficient evidence). An example might be a series of thefts on an Indian reservation where a suspect is identified but the U.S. Attorney doesn't think it's worth going to court. After exhausting all leads, the SSA and SAC can approve an administrative closure. The file is marked "Closed – Unresolved" (but not forgotten; if new evidence appears later, it can be reopened). The case agent would write a closing memo summarizing what was done and that no further action is anticipated absent new info. They'd ensure any evidence is properly stored or returned and that any sensitive sources are wrapped up. - **Referred or Handed Off:** Occasionally, the FBI opens a case but later realizes another agency is better suited or has taken lead. For instance, FBI might start a drug case and then determine it's best handled by DEA (Drug Enforcement Administration) since it's purely drug trafficking with no federal jurisdiction issues beyond DEA's mandate. In such a situation, the FBI case might be closed as "Referred to DEA – no further FBI action." Proper notifications are made, and any FBI-collected evidence or intel handed over. In Phoenix, given the collaborative environment with DEA on cartel cases <sup>30</sup>, this could happen if manpower is stretched – but typically FBI liked to see things through if they started it, unless jurisdiction said otherwise. - **Merging Cases:** If you discover that your case is part of a larger case (maybe another FBI office was investigating the same group), your case might be merged into theirs or vice versa. The duplicate file is closed and notes made to refer to the master file number. This happened often in multi-state investigations (e.g., two offices both chasing the same fugitive – one will take ownership, the other closes and contributes to the main case).

**Closing Procedure:** When closing, an agent ensures all loose ends are tied. That includes: - Returning or disposing of evidence per FBI policy (e.g., contraband drugs are destroyed under DEA supervision, stolen money returned to the bank, etc., with proper receipts). - If informants were used, closing them out or transferring them to another agent if they will continue providing info on other cases. - Completing a final **Case Closing EC** or memo that states the reason for closure (e.g., "Subject convicted and sentenced on X date, no further investigation pending, case closed."). - Notifying any victims if required (the FBI has victim/witness coordinators who ensure victims know the outcome, especially in violent crimes). - Updating records systems (mark the case closed in ACS, so it shows up in indices as closed, and entering the disposition details).

After closure, the case file is archived. By late 90s, files might be shipped to a records center after a few years of inactivity. However, the Bureau's indices (and by 1999, the new computerized systems) would still recall that file if needed. So, if a closed case later has a development – say your closed unresolved case from 1997 gets a DNA hit in 2005 – the FBI can resurrect that file from archives for follow-up.

**Example – Closing the Case:** In our kidnapping scenario, suppose the subject was caught and pleaded guilty, and the child was safely recovered. You, as case agent, would gather the final court documents (the plea agreement or judgment) and add them to the file. You fill out an **FD-515** noting one arrest, one conviction <sup>29</sup>, and any property recovered (say \$5,000 ransom recovered, one vehicle seized). You write a closing memo: "Subject John Doe was convicted in U.S. District Court, sentenced to 20 years. All evidence (list items) will be retained until appeal period expires then disposed per regulations. Victim notified. No further leads pending." You'd likely brief your squad at a meeting about the case's successful conclusion – closure is a time to share lessons learned too. The SSA signs off on your closure memo, and the case status in FBI records is updated to "Closed." If later someone in the Phoenix office or another office checks the name "John Doe" in FBI indices, they'll see a closed case file reference and can retrieve it, which might show up as something like "091A-PX-12345 closed 9/97 – Convicted" <sup>11</sup>.

In role-play, portraying the closure stage can be satisfying – it's where you wrap up, and maybe your character reflects on the outcome. It's also where an agent might get kudos or a bit of internal recognition (maybe a letter of commendation, or just the SAC's thanks at the quarterly meeting for a job well done). Conversely, if the case closed without resolution, you might portray some frustration but acceptance that you did all you could. Crucially, a good agent never actually "forgets" a closed unsolved case – they might keep an ear out for anything that could revive it. That's authentic to FBI culture: some leads simmer for years and agents will recall them if something triggers a memory.

With the case life cycle covered, we turn next to the bread-and-butter techniques agents use to work those cases: surveillance, undercover, informants, interviews, and more. That's the **tradecraft** in action on the street.

## Investigative Techniques and Fieldwork Practices

FBI agents in 1997 had a toolbox of investigative techniques to draw from. We'll cover several key areas: **surveillance** (both stationary "stakeouts" and mobile tailing), **undercover operations**, **handling informants and cooperating witnesses**, **conducting interviews and interrogations**, and **managing the flow of investigative leads**. Mastering these will let you depict an agent doing their job convincingly. We'll break each technique into its own subsection for clarity.

## Surveillance – Eyes on the Target

Surveillance is a core skill for many agents, especially on squads like violent crime, organized crime, or counterintelligence. There are two primary types: - **Stationary Surveillance (Stakeouts)** - **Mobile Surveillance (Tailing)**

**Stationary Surveillance (Stakeouts):** This is the classic stakeout – watching a fixed location (a suspect's house, a meeting spot, a drop site) without being detected. In 1997, an FBI stakeout involved patience and often boring hours. Agents might use unmarked cars or vans (with tinted windows) parked in strategic positions. In a city like Phoenix, you could blend in by using a utility van or an inconspicuous sedan. Agents often rotate during long surveillance to avoid fatigue. For example, two agents might take the 6am-2pm shift, then two more relieve them for 2pm-10pm, etc. Basic tradecraft: **don't draw attention**. The agents on a stakeout dress down (no suits – more like local casual clothing). They might use props – e.g., one agent with a newspaper pretending to read, or a fake maintenance van with signage to loiter in a neighborhood. High-end equipment in 1997 could include *telephoto cameras* (with actual film, since digital cams were primitive), maybe a **camcorder** if recording is needed (standard 8mm or VHS tapes), and **night vision scopes** if it's overnight (the FBI did have some night vision gear for low-light surveillance).

Communications on surveillance are done via **radio** – agents carry handheld radios or have car-mounted radios on a secure frequency. The FBI's radios in the 90s were typically VHF/UHF analog, often with encryption modules for sensitive operations. If you had multiple teams around a block, they'd be radioing positions: "Eye One to Eye Two, the package is on the move" (meaning the suspect left the location). **Code words** and brevity are used to avoid plain language that an eavesdropper could understand. For instance, they might refer to the suspect as "the package" or by a code name, and use predetermined codes for directions ("heading north" might be "heading 0-0-0" for 000 degrees). In a role-play scenario, you can sprinkle this lingo: "I radio, 'Car 1 in position, have eyes on the front door.'"

The challenges in a stakeout include staying awake (agents drink lots of coffee, and yes, "donut runs" can happen – sometimes an agent does a quick break to grab food for the team), maintaining cover (neighbors might get curious – in such case an agent might flash a fake ID like a utility worker badge or just have a cover story ready: "We're doing an insurance fraud surveillance"), and handling the unexpected (what if the suspect spots you? Then you might have to pull off and abort, or call in another team later). If the stakeout is on a public area, sometimes agents use **fixed hide sites** – e.g., an abandoned building across the street, or even set up a camera in a parked car that can be left unattended. By 1997 the FBI also had access to **pole cameras** (concealed cameras mounted on utility poles or elsewhere) for long-term monitoring of a place, especially in organized crime cases. These required approvals, but if installed, they feed video to a recording unit that agents can watch remotely.

An example stakeout: You suspect a bank robber is meeting his accomplice at a storage locker at midnight. You and three other agents set up around 11 PM. One car is parked down the street with a view of the locker entrance (Agent A with binoculars). Another agent (Agent B) is on foot dressed as a homeless person sitting on a bench near the area (yes, agents have been known to adopt such disguises for urban surveillance). You, Agent C, are in a car at the back exit of the storage facility, in case the suspects flee that way. When midnight hits, you see a car approaching the locker. You radio "Suspect vehicle arrived, two occupants, they're entering unit 24." The team stays quiet and observes. You photograph them carrying boxes (perhaps stolen loot?). You're ready in case they drive off – then you'd transition to mobile surveillance. In the end, say they leave and you do **not** attempt arrest (maybe waiting for more evidence).

After they're gone, you tail them a bit (more on mobile next) and then break off. You later write a **surveillance log** documenting everything seen and done, and add the photos to the case file (with an FD-302 describing the surveillance results).

**Mobile Surveillance (Tailing):** This is following a moving target – on foot or by vehicle. It's much trickier to do without being noticed. FBI agents often work mobile surveillance in teams of multiple cars, especially if the subject is driving. The key is to maintain visual contact without clustering obviously behind the suspect. A common technique is the "leapfrog" or "ABC method" – have at least three vehicles involved, where *Car A* stays a short distance behind the suspect, *Car B* is farther back, and *Car C* might be on parallel streets or ready to take over. They rotate positions periodically so no single car is always right behind the suspect (which could alert them). They communicate by radio to coordinate: "Target turning east on Camelback Road, Car B take the lead." In city traffic, this can be harrowing – red lights, congestion, etc., can break a surveillance. Agents have to drive somewhat aggressively but without drawing police attention themselves (nobody wants to get pulled over by a local cop for speeding while on a surveillance). In Phoenix, wide roads and grid layout can both help and hurt – lots of alternate routes to parallel someone, but also long stretches where a single car tail is obvious.

For foot surveillance (say downtown or at an airport), agents might split up coverage: one follows directly, another stays across the street, etc. They might use brief eye contact or hand signals to coordinate if talking into a wrist mic would be too obvious. The FBI in 1997 did use small wired earpieces and mics (think early "coil" earpieces), but a lot of foot surveillance was done by plainclothes agents without obvious comms, using tradecraft like following at a distance, ducking into cover if the target looks back (the old "reflection in store window" trick to watch someone behind you).

Mobile surveillance often involves **air support** too. The FBI might request an airplane or helicopter to track a moving car from above (the FBI had some aviation assets; if not locally, they could borrow from Customs or state police). A small Cessna plane with a surveillance team can follow a car without the suspects ever noticing (they rarely think to look up). However, in 1997 this is done for big cases or when expecting a long-distance tail.

Role-playing a mobile tail, use some lingo like: "I'm at a distance of 3-4 car lengths, keeping one car between me and the suspect when possible." If you think you're "made" (suspect might have spotted you), you'd radio to swap out or call off. The safety of not alerting the suspect often outweighs sticking on them at all costs – unless it's critical to not lose them. If critical, FBI might just throw caution out and continue even if "burned," or call in marked police to do a traffic stop if they fear losing the person.

Surveillance usually isn't a solitary activity. It's coordinated and methodical. It might last days or weeks. For instance, in an undercover sting, they may surveil a meeting from multiple vantage points (with one agent undercover in the meet, others nearby to swoop in if needed). A famous FBI practice is to establish an "**Ops Center**" during major surveillance – maybe a hotel room or a command post van where a case agent monitors incoming radio reports and tracks the target on a map in real-time. In a kidnapping scenario, an Ops Center might coordinate moving surveillances as ransom drop-offs happen.

One more aspect: **Surveillance Detection**. Good agents also check periodically if *they* are being watched. In a role-play scenario, your agent might suspect the suspect is running countersurveillance (e.g., taking weird detours, looking over their shoulder). If so, agents use anti-detection tactics like not all following at once, or even temporarily breaking off and picking up later rather than be confirmed by the suspect. In FBI training,

agents are taught how to spot if they're being counter-followed – in 90s, foreign spies often did “dry cleaning” (maneuvers to flush out tails). An FBI agent on a spy case in 1997 might do things like getting off the freeway and immediately back on to see if the same car does it, or taking three right turns in a city block (if someone is still behind you, you're being followed). For a criminal suspect, it's less common they do that, but savvy ones might.

**Example – Mobile Surveillance on a Robbery Suspect:** You and team suspect that a string of bank robberies in Phoenix are done by the same guy, and you have a possible plate from a witness. You locate the suspect's car at an apartment complex. Instead of arresting immediately, you want to follow him to see if he leads to accomplices or a stash. You set up in the morning. Suspect leaves at 8am in the car. You, in an unmarked SUV, follow as Car A. Another FBI car is a few blocks behind (Car B). He drives onto I-17 highway heading north. You radio “He's northbound on I-17 passing Camelback. I'm in sight.” Traffic is moderate. He doesn't seem to notice. Suddenly he exits unexpectedly; you signal to Car B to continue past while you exit with him. Now you're alone behind him on a surface street. He stops at a gas station. You park a half-block away, watching. He meets another man at the gas station – interesting. You snap a photo with a telephoto lens from inside your car. He then departs. This time, you let Car B take over as primary tail after he passes by your position. You become secondary. Over two hours, you manage to follow him to a storage unit (the possible loot hideout). At that point, you decide you have enough to get a warrant on the storage, and you don't want to risk burning the surveillance. You radio “Let's break – we have an ID on the location, we'll pick him up later.” Later that day, you regroup and plan an arrest at that storage with SWAT (tying into an operational plan as covered later). All your observations from the mobile surveillance – stops, meetings, addresses visited – go into a report, which strengthens your affidavit for a search warrant (“Agents observed SUBJECT meeting with an unidentified male and later going to 123 Mesa Storage, Unit 45” – establishing probable cause that evidence might be in that unit).

Through surveillance, your character can gather crucial intel without ever tipping off the suspect – but it requires discipline, backup, and knowing when to be a shadow and when to disengage.

## Undercover Operations – Playing a Role

Undercover work is one of the FBI's flashiest yet most sensitive techniques. It ranges from short-term stings (like posing as a buyer in a one-time drug deal) to long-term infiltrations of criminal organizations. Not every agent is an undercover agent; in fact, by 1997 the FBI had a system of selecting and training specialized **Undercover Employees (UCEs)** for deep covers. But any agent might do small “ruse” operations as needed. Let's break down how undercover tradecraft worked in the late 90s:

**Approval and Planning:** Undercover ops are tightly regulated. The Attorney General's **Undercover Guidelines** (updated through the 90s) required a detailed proposal for any long-term operation or any operation involving sensitive circumstances (like financial transactions, illegal activities, etc.) <sup>31</sup>. In practical terms, if your agent wants to go undercover beyond a simple one-time meeting, they'd need to write a **UC proposal** and get approval from FBIHQ and DOJ. For example, infiltrating a mob crew over months would require a proposal describing the scenario, fake identity to be used, what potential laws might be broken as part of maintaining cover, and how to mitigate risks <sup>32</sup> <sup>33</sup>. This goes up through the chain (SAC to HQ Criminal Division). That's for big stuff. For shorter, low-risk undercovers (like posing as a customer to buy stolen property once), the SAC could approve locally, but they still follow guidelines. In role-play, this means you can't just declare “I'm going undercover as a hitman for a year” on a whim – you'd play through the preparation phase, showing your character working within FBI rules.

**Cover Identities:** An undercover agent operates under a **cover identity** – a fictional persona. They often have fake IDs, backstopped credit history, and sometimes even props like business fronts or vehicles that match the cover. In 1997, creating a solid cover might involve coordination with FBIHQ's undercover and sensitive operations units. For instance, if you're posing as an arms dealer, the FBI might set up a dummy company or bank accounts to make it look legit. Phoenix Division in the 90s likely did some local undercovers for corruption or drug cases, but for more complex covers they might bring in a pro from out of division (so local criminals wouldn't recognize them). If your character is that undercover, you'd talk about your alias, maybe even practice your story (they call this "legending"). A simple cover might just be a fake name and story you verbally stick to. A complex cover might have counterfeit documents, a scripted background, and pre-made business cards.

**Undercover Safety and Oversight:** Undercover work is dangerous. Agents never go in without some **back-up team** knowing where they are and ready to intervene. Typically, an undercover meet will have surveillance agents nearby (as described earlier). Also, undercovers are usually instructed not to carry their FBI creds or real ID on them (in case they're searched by bad guys). They might carry a concealed weapon if it fits the role – or maybe not, if being unarmed won't blow cover and carrying could be discovered. The primary safety net is an "emergency signal" or code word. For example, an agent might have a pre-arranged phrase to say if things go south ("Tell the boss I left the stove on" over a hidden transmitter), or a visual signal (taking off a hat). Then the arrest team or cover team will swoop in. If no signal, the cover team still monitors and will act if clearly needed (like hearing an argument escalate).

**Legal constraints – Entrapment and Allowed Crimes:** A big part of FBI undercover policy is avoiding **entrapment**. Entrapment, in simple terms, is inducing someone to commit a crime they weren't already willing to do. FBI agents must be able to later testify, **truthfully**, that "the defendant was already willing to do this, we merely gave them the opportunity" <sup>34</sup> <sup>35</sup>. To ensure this, agents are trained not to be the ones suggesting the crime in an undercover capacity if it can be helped – let the suspect articulate the criminal plan or desire. For example, if undercover, you wouldn't say "Hey, why don't you go rob a bank and I'll help?" Instead, you let *them* approach or at least express interest first. It's okay to play along and provide the opportunity (say, as an illegal arms seller ready to supply a bomb) but not okay to plant the idea of a crime in their head <sup>36</sup>. In gameplay, if you're undercover, try to prompt the NPC to suggest the illegal act or confirm their intent, rather than you pushing it. That keeps your agent on the right side of entrapment law.

Also, undercovers (and informants) **cannot freely commit crimes**. The FBI can *authorize* certain minor or necessary criminal acts to maintain cover (called "otherwise illegal activity" or OIA in paperwork). For example, an agent might be allowed to handle a small quantity of drugs during a deal, or drive a getaway car after a fake transaction, because those acts further the investigation and are relatively minor <sup>37</sup> <sup>38</sup>. But there are bright lines: no violence, no initiating serious crimes. By the 90s, any "**churning**" (reinvesting crime proceeds to keep a cover going) or larger illegal acts had to be approved by DOJ in advance <sup>32</sup> <sup>39</sup>. If a criminal asks the undercover to do something unapproved and too severe (like "help me kill someone"), the undercover must stall or get out – the operation may be terminated rather than allow an agent to commit a major crime <sup>33</sup> <sup>40</sup>. A mantra often cited: "*Don't create crime, only catch it.*" Or as a training quote: "**Informants can lie and informants can die, but they can't be allowed to just commit crimes**" <sup>41</sup> – meaning informants and undercovers aren't given carte blanche to wreak havoc.

**Operational Example – Short-term UC Sting:** A Phoenix agent gets a tip that a local businessman is looking to hire a hitman to kill a rival. The FBI decides to do a sting. You volunteer to be the "hitman" undercover. Because this is sensitive (murder-for-hire) but likely a one-time meet, the SAC can approve it

with DOJ concurrence without a huge operation plan. You prepare by lightly disguising yourself – maybe you grow a beard, wear biker attire if the character would plausibly contact a biker as a hitman. You adopt a fake name, “Nick.” An informant introduces you to the businessman in a controlled meeting. You have a transmitter (a “wire”) on you so the cover team hears everything – one-party consent recordings are legal, meaning since *you* consent to the recording as the undercover, it’s admissible <sup>42</sup>. During the meeting at a bar, the target says he’ll pay \$5,000 to have his rival killed. You play it cool: “I can do that, but I need half up front.” He gives you money and a photo of the intended victim – **boom, evidence obtained**. You maybe stall on actually doing anything (“I’ll be in touch when it’s done”). Once you walk out and give a bust signal, the surveillance agents arrest the guy on solicitation of murder charges. This classic sting is quick and gets the goods in one go <sup>43</sup> <sup>44</sup>. As the undercover, you’d later testify that he was fully willing – you didn’t pressure him, he was looking for a killer already.

**Operational Example – Long-term Undercover:** Say the Phoenix Division wants to take down a ring of corrupt public officials taking bribes (could be a hypothetical inspired by real cases). They might set up a front company and have an undercover agent pose as a wealthy investor offering kickbacks for city contracts. This could run for months, with multiple meetings, phone calls (recorded), and maybe even paying out small bribes (with DOJ-approved funds). The undercover agent would write **daily contact memos** (FD-209, though usually for informants it’s FD-209, for an agent undercover they’d still document contacts similarly) <sup>45</sup> to record each interaction so nothing is forgotten. They maintain their cover story consistently. All the while, supervisors monitor the case closely – often there’s an undercover coordinator agent not involved in the cover who tracks safety and adherence to the scenario. Such operations can reel in many targets, but are only done when the payoff is big because of the resources and risks involved.

From a role-play perspective, undercover work allows for some fun acting within acting – your character pretending to be someone else. But remember to portray the **tension**: an undercover is always balancing authenticity with caution. You might show your agent’s inner thoughts of stress (“Heart pounding as I hand the crime boss the bag of fake money, hoping he doesn’t notice my hand shaking slightly”). And if someone starts to suspect you (“Are you a cop?”), you have to either laugh it off (“If I were a cop, would I do *this*?”) or play angry at the accusation – anything to keep trust. Undercover agents also often have pre-arranged **escape strategies**. For instance, your agent might have a story ready to leave suddenly if needed (“Sorry, I gotta go, my kid’s sick”) or an actual physical back-up like a fellow agent posing as a random person who can intervene (“drunk bar patron” agent starts a distraction fight so you can slip out). In dire cases, the agent can use an **emergency phrase** – e.g., saying the wrong name or asking an odd question that signals “come get me out.” The team then might rush in as “police” to bust the whole scenario.

Finally, once an undercover assignment ends (either by arrests or by being pulled out), the agent is debriefed and often pulled off regular duty for a bit to decompress, especially if it was long-term. In 1997, mental health for undercovers wasn’t as openly discussed as now, but the Bureau did recognize the strain and often undercovers wouldn’t jump back into another role immediately.

Undercover work can yield dramatic evidence (nothing quite like the bad guy on tape saying “Yeah, I want the bomb built, here’s the cash” <sup>42</sup>). But it’s always the method of last resort if other techniques can’t do the job, due to its complexity and risk. That’s why you see FBI using it most in organized crime, public corruption, or terror cases where a mole on the inside is golden. In a typical violent crime case (bank robbery, etc.), undercovers aren’t as common unless it’s to recover stolen goods or something.

## Informants and Cooperating Witnesses – Handling Human Sources

Human sources can be *incredibly* valuable in FBI investigations. The Bureau differentiates between **Confidential Informants (CIs)** and **Cooperating Witnesses (CWs)**, though in conversation agents might loosely say “informant” for both. By 1997, FBI policy on informants was well-established: there were formal rules on how to recruit, document, and control informants <sup>46</sup> <sup>47</sup>. Let’s break down what it means to manage informants/CWs, and how an agent interacts with these often shady but useful characters.

**Informant vs. Cooperating Witness:** - A **Confidential Informant (CI)** is usually someone who provides information covertly and often expects something in return (money, or leniency in their own criminal case, or just the thrill or a sense of civic duty). They may or may not ever testify in court. The FBI keeps their identity confidential as long as possible. Think of a CI as an ongoing “asset” inside a criminal world. - A **Cooperating Witness (CW)** typically is someone who *has been caught* and is now cooperating to get a reduced sentence or immunity. They usually *do* testify eventually (like a member of a gang who flips and testifies against his pals). A CW might operate like an informant for a while (wear a wire, help set up stings) but with the understanding their name will come out in court as a witness. The FBI still protects them but slightly different expectations (since they will be revealed in legal process).

**Recruitment and Opening of an Informant:** An agent can’t just start pumping someone for info and call them an informant formally. FBI rules say you must “**open**” an informant file on them – this involves identifying them (the Bureau will run background checks, criminal history, etc.), giving them a code name or number, and getting authorization from higher-ups to use them <sup>48</sup>. For example, you meet a low-level mob associate who is willing to feed info. You’d submit an informant opening request to your SSA and the Informant Coordinator of the office. You have to note any issues like are they on probation, are they reliable or just telling tales, what their motivations might be (money? fear of rivals? etc.) <sup>49</sup>. Once approved, they might be designated “PHX-CI-12-97” (Phoenix informant opened in 2012? Actually, probably a code like PHX-1234-CI or something in records). The agent often gives them a nickname for internal use (e.g. CI “Desert Ghost” or something) so even in internal emails they don’t use the real name.

**Informant Agreements:** The informant usually signs an **informant agreement** acknowledging they aren’t a law enforcement employee, that they can’t break the law (except specific approved activity), and they understand they could get dropped if they lie or misbehave. There might not be a specific FD form printed in public, but it’s part of opening them (and some offices did use a standard admonishment form). The agent will make it clear: “We’ll protect your identity as best we can, and we may compensate you, but you must follow our directions and not commit crimes without telling me.” Informants at this time had a bit of a notorious history (due to issues like Whitey Bulger – an informant who corrupted agents – which by the late 90s the FBI was very wary of). So agents in ‘97 are trained to be **skeptical and careful** with informants.

**Documenting Informant Contacts:** Every time you meet or talk with a CI, you file a **Contact Report (FD-209)** detailing when, where, and what info they provided <sup>50</sup>. The FD-209 also notes if any payment was given or if the informant engaged in activity on behalf of the FBI. This is critical for later court disclosure and for internal audits (the **Jencks Act** means if an informant testifies, all those reports might have to be given to defense <sup>51</sup>, so you write as if one day a defense lawyer will read it). FBI policy says these contact reports should be filed within a few days of contact <sup>52</sup> – procrastinating could get you in trouble, as every 90 days a supervisor must review the informant’s file (there’s an **FD-675 Informant File Review Log** for that) <sup>53</sup> <sup>54</sup>.

**Payments and Expenses:** Many informants get paid for info or work. The FBI budget includes informant payments, but it's all receipted. If you pay a CI \$500 for some intel, you fill out a **Receipt for Informant Payment (FD-777)** and ideally have the informant sign it (or if they won't sign, you note that) <sup>55</sup>. You also need a supervisor's approval for any significant payment. Agents can't just dole out cash freely – there's oversight to prevent abuse. There's often a ceiling amount before HQ needs to approve. In 1997, small payments might be local, large payments (thousands) might need HQ okay. The records of all this go in the informant's file, not the main case file (for confidentiality, the case file might just refer to them as "CI-1 provided information that..." but not by name).

**Controlling Illegal Activity by Informants:** Like undercovers, informants might have to do borderline illegal things to be credible (e.g., an informant in a drug gang might have to be present at a drug deal). The FBI can authorize this in a limited way. It's called **Otherwise Illegal Activity (OIA)** and is documented with approvals. An agent must write down what they are allowing: e.g. "CI may purchase one ounce of cocaine as sample, but will not participate beyond that." The supervisor and likely the SAC sign off. If an informant goes rogue and does unapproved crimes, the agent must report it and likely terminate them. The motto as mentioned: informants are an investigative tool, *not* free criminals <sup>40</sup> <sup>56</sup>. In 1997, FBI agents were particularly mindful after some high-profile cases where informants committed murder or dealt drugs and claimed FBI immunity. So your character would be careful not to let an informant run wild – frequent check-ins, and if the informant says "I have to rough someone up to maintain cover," the agent would likely say "No, we'll find another way" or pull them out.

**Trust and Mistrust:** An agent's relationship with an informant can be complex. On one hand, you need them to trust you and keep feeding info. You might be friendly, even social at times (meeting at diners, chatting about life to build rapport). On the other hand, you *never* fully trust them – many informants are criminals or have their own agenda. They might lie or embellish to get paid or to get a rival in trouble. A savvy agent cross-checks informant info with other evidence whenever possible. If an informant says "X is the killer," you don't arrest X solely on that – you use it as a lead to gather independent proof. Also, if an informant is working off charges (common scenario: a small-time dealer gets caught, DEA or FBI flips them to rat on bigger dealers), you keep in touch with the prosecutor about how much they're helping (for later sentencing considerations). But you also worry they might still commit crimes on the side – some do. Part of your job is being almost a handler and a bit of a probation officer for them. FBI files have **Informant Review Sheets (FD-237)** with periodic evaluations of their productivity and reliability <sup>57</sup> <sup>58</sup>.

**Protecting Identity:** The FBI goes to lengths to protect an informant's identity, because exposure can mean retaliation or simply they dry up. Internally, they're referred by code or number. When filing court papers, if you need to mention them, they might be "Source #T-5" or such. Only if the case goes to trial and the informant is needed as a witness do you "surface" them (reveal them). If not, sometimes the FBI and prosecutors try to avoid using them overtly by finding other ways to introduce evidence. However, under **Brady/Giglio** rules, if an informant's info is used to get evidence, eventually defense might be told an informant was involved if it's relevant to the defense (especially if it could show bias, like they were paid) <sup>51</sup>. So, an agent must keep detailed records to provide to prosecutors. For example, if a case goes to trial that used a CI's tip to get a search warrant, the defense might demand to know if someone was paid to provide that tip – because it could be bias. The FBI then has to at least disclose that to the judge in camera if not outright.

**Cooperating Witnesses:** Now, if instead of a long-term CI, you have a **cooperating witness** – say you arrest a member of a bank robbery crew and he agrees to flip and testify – the handling is similar but with

some differences. You still document every debrief (on FD-302s typically, since once they're more a witness than a secret informant). You might even have them sign a **proffer letter** with the prosecutor (that's handled by AUSA – basically an agreement on how their info will be used and what they get in return, like immunity or a plea). As an agent, you then might direct them to make recorded calls to co-conspirators (with their consent we can record – one party consent law again <sup>42</sup>), or have them wear a wire to a meeting, etc., similar to a CI. The difference is, you know at trial this person will be revealed, so you're preparing them for that role: coaching them to some degree on how to be truthful and not embellish, reminding them to stick to facts. Also, you ensure any **benefit** they get (like you promised to tell the judge about their cooperation) is well-documented and will be disclosed, so that it doesn't torpedo the case later when revealed.

**Example – Using an Informant:** Let's say Phoenix FBI is investigating a car theft ring tied to a local gang. You have a guy on the inside as an informant – maybe a low-level gang member who got busted for drugs and agreed to inform. You meet with CI “Tomcat” once a week. In one meeting at a park (neutral location), he tells you that the gang is planning to steal a shipment of luxury cars from a rail yard. You ask for details: when, who, what route they might take. You possibly equip him with a small recorder to secretly capture any planning conversations (if he's willing and it won't blow his cover). You give him \$300 for his info this time (after discussing with your SSA) because it's particularly useful intel – and you fill out the FD-777 payment receipt and he signs with his code name <sup>55</sup>. Now you scramble your squad to set up a sting at that rail yard at the given time. Sure enough, it happens as he said – you catch the gang in the act. Many get arrested. Now, **do you use Tomcat in court?** If his intel led directly to the bust, you might not need him to testify because you caught the crew committing the crime red-handed. However, defense might ask “How did you know to be there at that time?” The prosecutor can often answer vaguely (“We received a tip from a confidential source”) and that might suffice. But if any of the defendants demand more, the judge might insist on more detail – sometimes it becomes a battle to protect a CI's ID versus the defendant's right to a fair trial. The FBI might even choose to drop certain charges rather than expose the CI. Let's assume in this case the evidence is strong enough without revealing him. Tomcat lives to inform another day, and maybe you'll use him for future cases. You continue meeting, but now that the gang suspects a leak (they often will after a bust like that), Tomcat might be in danger. You might relocate him or have him lay low. Maybe he becomes a **witness protection candidate** if his info is that valuable and he's at risk – that requires DOJ processes and the U.S. Marshals Service (WITSEC program). In a 90s-themed game, you could explore that drama: evacuating an informant whose cover is blown, giving him a new identity.

**Example – Cooperating Witness Flip:** You arrest a white-collar criminal – say an accountant involved in a fraud – and he agrees to help bring down the mastermind in exchange for a lighter sentence. He's now a cooperating witness. Over weeks, you debrief him in detail – each session you do a 302 of what he tells you (he explains the whole fraud scheme). You have him wear a wire in a meeting with the mastermind to get incriminating statements. That works: you get tape of the boss saying “Yeah, cook those books like we did last year.” At trial, this cooperating witness will testify to authenticate those tapes and explain the scheme. You prepare him with the AUSA – doing mock Q&A to practice, warning him that defense will attack his credibility (“They'll say you're only testifying to save your own skin – how will you answer?”). You also make sure all his prior lies or crimes are disclosed so nothing is a surprise (part of Giglio requirements, any impeachment info has to be out in the open). When he takes the stand, you as case agent might sit at the prosecution table (as case agents often do <sup>59</sup>) and you'll have to be ready if defense asks him about every meeting he had with you – those FD-302s might be used to refresh his memory or even handed to defense under Jencks Act after he testifies <sup>60</sup>.

For role-play, handling informants is a chance to show a more nuanced side of your agent. Perhaps you express some ethical conflict – using and perhaps betraying the trust of a criminal to get bigger fish. Some agents get very invested in “their CI” to the point of risking being duped (like the famous mob informants who compromised agents). In 1997, awareness of that was high, so an experienced agent is cautious. You might play your agent as guarded: you keep the relationship business-like. Or if you trust the informant somewhat, you might act more collegial – meeting at a bar, sharing small talk. But you’ll likely never fully turn your back on them, figuratively and literally, because you know desperation can make them dangerous. Standard safety: often two agents go to an informant meet (one primary handler, one backup overwatch) to ensure the handler doesn’t get hurt or conned without witness. If your character is the handler, maybe mention you have your partner nearby watching. And of course, never promise more than you can deliver: agents can’t *guarantee* an informant will avoid jail or get rich – they can only recommend or pay within guidelines. Honesty (to a point) is usually the policy: “Tom, I can’t promise the judge will go easy on you, but I’ll make sure the prosecutor knows about all the help you gave us. It will count for something.” That’s a realistic line.

## Interviewing and Interrogation – Getting Information from People

One of the most common activities for any FBI agent is talking to people – whether it’s a witness, a victim, a suspect, or some expert. This could be a friendly chat or a tense interrogation. The ability to conduct effective interviews while respecting legal boundaries (and knowing when it crosses into “custodial interrogation” requiring rights warnings) is crucial. Let’s look at how agents in 1997 approached interviews:

**Preparation:** A good agent does homework before an interview. If you’re interviewing a witness, you review what you already know so you can ask informed questions and test consistency. If it’s a suspect, you gather any evidence already available to confront them if they lie. Agents often draft a list of key questions or points to cover, though actual questions may flow with the conversation. In role-play, you might say “Before heading to the interview, I review the case file and jot down the main things I need to ask about.” If it’s a planned interrogation of a suspect, agents might also coordinate a strategy (Good Cop/Bad Cop roles, etc.) with their partner.

**Approach and Demeanor:** FBI agents in the field typically identify themselves at the outset of an interview (except undercover of course). For a non-custodial interview (the person is not under arrest and free to leave), it might be at their home or workplace: “*Good afternoon, I’m Special Agent Jane Doe with the FBI*” (showing creds briefly) “*I’d like to ask you a few questions about...*”. The demeanor can range from friendly and low-key for cooperative witnesses, to firm and assertive for tougher subjects. Generally, Bureau training encourages starting polite and professional; you can always become more confrontational if needed, but it’s hard to dial back if you start hostile. For witnesses and victims, the agent often shows empathy, listening patiently. For suspects (especially if not under arrest yet), the agent will be cordial but observant – trying to win their confidence or at least keep them talking, while looking for deceit.

**Two Agents Present:** The FBI’s practice is to have two agents (or an agent and a detective, if joint) for important interviews whenever possible. One leads the questioning, the other is a **note-taker and observer**. This serves multiple purposes: it provides a witness to what was said (useful if the person later changes their story or accuses the agent of misconduct), it allows one person to focus on listening while the other asks questions, and it can help in strategy (they can take turns, one can go out and come back with documents as a tactic, etc.). So your character might bring their partner along to the interview of a suspect

at their home. One agent might stand a bit off to the side, subtly watching body language and taking light notes.

**Miranda and Custodial Interrogation:** A critical distinction: **If a person is in custody (not free to leave) and you are interrogating (asking guilt-seeking questions)**, you *must* Mirandize them (read them their rights). In 1997, FBI agents carry a **Miranda card (FD-395)** <sup>61</sup>, sometimes a pocket-sized one <sup>62</sup>, and a form the suspect can sign to waive their rights. So, if you arrest someone and want to interview them, the first step: “You have the right to remain silent...” etc. (the standard Miranda warning), then have them sign FD-395 acknowledging they understand and will talk <sup>61</sup>. FBI policy was to always get a signed waiver if possible, as that is strong in court to show it was voluntary. If the person invokes their right to silence or lawyer, questioning stops (per Supreme Court rulings). Agents in 1997 were well-versed in this; the Bureau drilled adherence to 5th Amendment rights after some high-profile cases in past decades. In-game, if you forget to Mirandize an in-custody suspect, the GM might penalize by making their statement inadmissible or causing other trouble, so best practice: explicitly mention reading rights and having suspect sign the form when applicable.

For **non-custodial** interviews (the person is free to break it off and walk away), you do *not* Mirandize, because that could needlessly alarm them (“Am I under arrest? Why are you reading me rights?”). A lot of FBI interviews are in this category – you catch someone in a comfortable environment, ask questions, and they are technically free not to answer or to ask you to leave. Many will talk because it’s the FBI asking – that carries weight – and because it’s informal. If mid-interview someone tries to leave and you physically block them or implicitly make them stay, it’s sliding to custody – and agents avoid that without rights given. Better to let them go and try later or switch tactics, than violate rights and lose the statement. So, as a player, make clear delineation: “We interview Bob at his shop. He’s not under arrest, so we don’t Mirandize. We just chat in his office with the door open, making it clear he’s helping voluntarily.”

**Interview Techniques:** FBI agents utilize many standard interviewing techniques: - **Rapport Building:** Start with easy questions or common ground to make the person comfortable. “I appreciate you taking the time. Nice family photo – is that Sedona? I love hiking up there.” A bit of small talk can loosen tongues. - **Direct vs. Indirect Questions:** Sometimes direct (“Did you see John on Tuesday night?”), sometimes indirect or open-ended (“Tell me about how you spent Tuesday.”). Indirect can catch inconsistencies because you’re not signaling the answer you expect. - **Verifying Details:** Ask the same thing in different ways at different times to see if the story holds. Honest witnesses usually stay consistent; liars often slip up. - **Confrontation with Evidence:** If you have evidence, often you hold it back initially. Let them lie if they will, then present the evidence: “That’s funny, because we have video of you at the bank at 3 PM.” But the FBI also teaches not to lie about evidence in one aspect: you shouldn’t claim fake evidence (“We found your fingerprints” when you didn’t) – that’s generally legal to do (police can lie in interrogations), but FBI culture historically was a bit more conservative about outright fabrications, preferring to use real evidence for impact. That said, some agents did use deception when necessary (like implying they have a witness when they don’t). It’s a gray area. Use with caution if role-playing – maybe limited, like “We heard some strong evidence placing you there” without specifics. - **Note-taking:** In witness interviews, often one agent takes notes openly. In suspect interrogations, sometimes agents don’t take extensive notes in real-time (to not break flow or appear skeptical); instead they might jot down critical quotes or times, then write the full 302 after. However, any notes taken are technically discoverable by defense if kept, so some agents destroy their rough notes after finalizing the 302 (this was a common practice though controversial). But a training tip: focus on the

conversation, not writing every word – key details only, then write your memo ASAP after, while memory fresh.

- **Body Language and Demeanor:** The FBI trains agents to observe body language (fidgeting, eye contact, tone changes) for signs of truth or stress. They also consider their own posture: a non-threatening stance for rapport, or leaning in and staring for pressure when confronting a lie.
- **Good Cop/Bad Cop:** Sometimes used – one agent might act understanding (“I get it, anyone could’ve made that mistake...”) while the other is tougher (“But this is serious. You better come clean.”). This psychological play can wear a suspect down. It’s a bit cliché but it is used. Just don’t overact into parody.

**During the Interview:** If the person is cooperative, an FBI agent often just lets them talk, steering gently. If the person is hostile or lying, agents may press harder, even raise their voice a bit, show evidence, or imply consequences (“Lying to a federal agent is a crime of its own, you know. It’s better if you’re truthful now.” Indeed, 18 U.S.C. § 1001 makes false statements a crime). Agents have to be careful about promises: they shouldn’t promise leniency they can’t deliver (“If you confess, I promise you won’t go to jail” – not allowed). They can say “I’ll tell the prosecutor you cooperated,” which is truthful and often done.

In 1997, recording interviews was *not* routine for the FBI. In fact, the Bureau generally prohibited recording interrogations of suspects, preferring the written 302 summary (this changed in later decades, but in the 90s it was standard). Defense attorneys would often attack this practice, but it was ingrained: the idea being agents can focus on subject and get more info without a recorder possibly making the suspect nervous. So in an interrogation scene, you likely would not have a tape recorder rolling, unless it was a strategic one (like a phone call being recorded with consent). If a suspect later claims “I didn’t say that,” it becomes agent’s word vs suspect’s – which juries often trust the agent, especially if two agents heard it <sup>63</sup>. But as the legal handbook notes, defense lawyers in the 90s did cross-examine agents on why no recording <sup>64</sup>. So maybe your character thinks ahead: “This guy’s likely to lie later; I’ll make sure both of us agents witness everything, and I’ll write a thorough 302.” Possibly even invite a detective or third person in to further corroborate if it’s a big confession.

**After the Interview:** Immediately after, the agents compare notes and ensure they got the same understanding. Then they prepare the **FD-302** report. The 302 should include all substantive information. Minor chit-chat not needed, but any admission or key detail absolutely included, and even the questions if important (like “When confronted with the video, SUBJECT admitted X”). If the interview was of a suspect and yielded a confession or partial admission, the agents might also prepare a separate **written statement** for the suspect to sign (less common but sometimes, they’d handwrite or type a confession for them to sign). However, many suspects won’t sign something, even if they spoke it, out of fear. In any case, the agents’ testimony will be the primary evidence of that statement in court. Under the **Jencks Act (18 U.S.C. § 3500)**, once the agent testifies about what the suspect said, the defense is entitled to the 302 report to cross-examine <sup>60</sup>. So it needs to be accurate.

**Example – Witness Interview:** You’re investigating a bank robbery. You go to interview a bank teller who was on duty. You introduce yourself, make them comfortable in a quiet room, and go through the events. You ask open-endedly “Tell me everything you remember about the robber.” She gives a description. You occasionally ask clarifying questions: “Did you notice any accent in his voice?” You take notes. She’s nervous, so you reassure: “You’re doing great – anything you recall can help us.” She remembers a tattoo on his neck.

Important! You ask details: “What kind of tattoo, roughly? Color? Shape?” She says maybe a snake. All noted. After finishing, you thank her and give her your card, telling her to call if she recall anything else later (memory can return). That evening, you write a 302 of the interview, including that she described a tattoo of possibly a snake on the left side of the neck, etc. This now goes into your case file, and will be shared with the AUSA and possibly used to get a search or arrest warrant (“description given by an eyewitness teller”) – establishing your probable cause partly <sup>65</sup> .

**Example – Suspect Interrogation:** The police arrest a suspect on a related charge and hand him over to you (federal). He’s now in custody at the Phoenix Police station, in an interview room. You and your partner decide to try to get a confession. You Mirandize him first using your FD-395 card: he says he understands and agrees to talk, signing the waiver <sup>61</sup> . You start by a bit of rapport – “That’s a ASU Sun Devils tattoo on your arm? You a fan?” – then ease into the crime. At first he denies everything. You use a **theme**: “Look, we know times are tough and maybe you fell into a bad crowd. We already have evidence you were there. If you own up to it, it’ll show you’re trying to make it right.” This is a mild technique of moral justification. He hesitates. You then play a card: show him a photo from the bank’s security camera that looks like him. It’s grainy but enough to spook him. He sighs and admits, “Alright, I was there, but I was just the lookout!” Boom, partial confession. You drill down: “Who was the guy who went inside? What’s his name?” He gives up a name. You keep him talking to get all details – maybe even about other robberies. He refuses to sign a written statement (“I told you, isn’t that enough?”). That’s fine, you’ve got it verbally. You conclude politely: “Thank you for your honesty. We’ll let the prosecutor know you cooperated.” (Not a promise, but implying help which is true). After, you and partner lock in what he said and ensure your notes cover it. On your 302, you’ll write essentially a narrative of the interrogation: “After being advised of his Miranda rights and waiving them, John Doe admitted to acting as a lookout in the robbery of First Bank. He stated that his accomplice was [Name]. Doe claimed he did not enter the bank but waited outside... etc.” If it goes to trial, both of you might testify to his confession (and indeed, often FBI pairs testify together to reinforce credibility – one might have slightly different recollection, but generally they back each other up).

**Special cases – polygraph:** In the 90s, the FBI sometimes used polygraph exams in investigations (especially counterintelligence, or to clear suspects). Polygraph results aren’t typically admissible in court, but are a tool. If a suspect agrees, a FBI polygraph examiner (often at the field office or a specialist flown in) hooks them up and asks questions. The agent monitors. If the suspect “fails” (deceptive responses indicated), the agent might use that to pressure them (“The polygraph isn’t going well for you, maybe you should tell us the truth.”). If they pass, sometimes it steers the investigation elsewhere (though polygraphs are not foolproof). An agent must get the person’s consent to polygraph (there’s a form FD-328) <sup>66</sup> . For role-play, you might mention offering a polygraph in tough cases, as it was part of FBI practice, albeit with mixed reliability.

**Cross-cultural or special interviews:** In a place like Phoenix, you might have Spanish-speaking witnesses or subjects. FBI typically had some Spanish-speaking agents or used interpreters. If you use an interpreter, you note that in the 302 and include both the question and translated answer process. Another example: interviews on Native American reservations (federal jurisdiction in Indian Country) – agents often coordinate with tribal police; sensitivity to culture is important.

In summary, interviewing is both an art and a science for an FBI agent. Show your character as prepared, methodical, and aware of the legal boundaries. Don’t be afraid to have them take a break in the middle of an interrogation to strategize (“We step out of the room to discuss next steps while he has a smoke.” That’s common – leaving the suspect stewing alone for a few minutes can increase anxiety and desire to talk). And

always, always, circle back to documentation. The interview isn't over until the paperwork is done, as far as the FBI is concerned.

## Managing and Tracking Leads – “Following the Bread Crumbs”

We touched on lead management earlier, but it deserves its own short focus as a “technique” because knowing how to pursue investigative leads effectively is critical tradecraft. A **lead** is any task or line of inquiry that might advance the case – from “interview that guy” to “analyze those phone records” to “check the suspect’s alibi.” In the FBI, especially in multi-agent cases, organizing who does what and ensuring everything is covered is a big job.

**Lead Office vs. Assist Office:** As mentioned, the **Office of Origin** (where the case is based) can send leads to **Office of Assistance** (another field office). This is done formally, often as an EC (Electronic Communication) addressed to that field division. For example, Phoenix might send: “Lead to Los Angeles – conduct neighborhood canvas at address XYZ for any info on suspect’s associates.” The LA office would assign an agent, who’d do it and send back a report (which Phoenix files). When you get that back, you mark the lead as *covered*. In the 90s, this was largely a manual checklist; some squads had clerks who tracked pending leads in a spreadsheet or on paper. If something was aging, the case agent would send a follow-up. Good practice: if LA hasn’t responded in a month, you call their supervisor to politely inquire.

**Ticklers and Deadlines:** Many agents keep a “**tickler file**” – reminders of actions that need follow-up. This could be a calendar, or literally index cards or a section in a notebook. For example: “Subpoena phone records – expected return by Aug 5 – follow up if not received.” In role-play, mention revisiting your notes or tickler to check what’s outstanding. Perhaps “It’s been two weeks since we asked ATF for that gun trace, I’ll call to check status.” That’s authentic – proactive follow-up is key in real investigations. Letting a lead slip through cracks might mean a case stalls or a bad guy flees.

**Prioritization:** Not all leads are equal. An FBI agent will triage: “Must do now” vs “Do when time permits.” They’ll also categorize by type: **investigative (fieldwork)** vs **analytical (paperwork)**. Maybe top priority is “Arrest subject’s known associate before he runs” – that’s immediate. Lower might be “Compile financial records for prosecution” – important but can be done over a few days. In an FBI office, each morning a case agent might make a quick plan: today I’ll tackle A, B, C. In group meetings, teams discuss leads so nothing is forgotten. Often the SSA will ask, “What’s the status of lead XYZ?” to keep pressure on.

**Keeping the AUSA in loop:** If it’s a prosecutorial matter, the AUSA (Assistant U.S. Attorney) might also suggest leads (“We need to prove this element, can you find out X?”). Those become part of your plan. Conversely, if an AUSA says a certain lead isn’t needed or legally can’t be done (like an iffy search), you may drop it.

**Avoiding Overlap and Conflict:** When multiple agencies or squads are involved, sometimes duplicate leads happen (two people unknowingly plan to interview the same person). FBI tradecraft encourages clear communication to avoid this. That’s why case agents coordinate: “We already talked to that witness, share what we got so DEA doesn’t hit them again the next day and confuse them.” In the Phoenix context, if say a kidnapping case overlaps with a tribal police investigation, leads on the reservation might be done jointly to avoid stepping on toes.

**Using Analytical Tools:** In 1997, the FBI is beginning to have more computer databases. For leads involving records, the agent might use tools like: **NCIC** (criminal records/warrants search) <sup>28</sup>, **FinCEN** for financial leads (FinCEN is Treasury's Financial Crimes Enforcement Network which collates suspicious financial transactions), **telephone toll analysis** (pen registers, pulling phone logs to see who called whom – sometimes done by analysts using computer programs to map out connections). The FBI's nascent **Automated Case Support (ACS)** system could also help search if other cases had similar MO or names. But a lot is still legwork and phone calls. Agents rely on resources: if you need a DMV check in another state, you call that state's DMV or FBI office liaison. If you need an international lead, you might send it to FBI **Legal Attaché** in the relevant country or go through Interpol. That's more specialized, but big cases do it.

**Closing the Loop:** After covering a lead, you often generate *new* leads. Example: you interview a witness (lead done) and they mention a second person of interest – new lead to interview that second person. This branching continues until you hopefully reach an endpoint (solved or exhausted). It's like a decision tree that expands and then you prune it as you go. A good investigator knows when to stop, too – chasing every possible tangent can waste time. So part of lead management is recognizing diminishing returns (“We could interview the suspect's third-grade teacher... but that's likely irrelevant”).

**Example – Lead Management in a Serial Case:** You're case agent on a serial arson case in Phoenix. You have 50 leads open: lab tests, interviews, liaising with the fire department, etc. You set up a board in the squad area listing each arson incident and what's known. You assign certain leads: your partner takes half the witness interviews, you take the others. You send a lead to the FBI lab for chemical analysis of residues (the lab itself is like an assist office, it'll produce a report). You send another to ATF (they also investigate arsons, and FBI often works joint) to check their bomb database. You also ask the Behavioral Analysis Unit for a profile of the arsonist (lead to Quantico experts). Over weeks, info trickles in: lab results (maybe hint at same accelerant used), ATF says no match in their database, BAU suggests type of offender. Each time you get something, you mark those leads “completed” and often they spawn next steps (lab says accelerant is a certain rare chemical – new lead: find suppliers of that chemical in Arizona and see who bought it). Eventually, one lead pans out (a purchase record leads to a suspect). Now you focus all remaining leads on that suspect: background checks, surveillance, etc. Some earlier unproductive leads get closed off (e.g., you had a lead to interview a suspect who turned out uninvolved – you document it and close it). When the case is over, a thorough case file will show a trail of dozens of leads covered – it demonstrates to FBIHQ and prosecutors that you left no stone unturned, but also only pursued logical ones.

In role-play, showing your character systematically pursuing leads (instead of magically jumping to the culprit) adds realism. Perhaps you even have them frustrated at times: “We've run 20 leads and we're still empty-handed” – that's a real feeling agents get. Then one break comes and it rejuvenates them. You can also incorporate the bureaucratic side: “I spend the morning drafting lead requests to three other field offices and our lab – a bit of paperwork, but necessary.” Those are exactly the unglamorous but real tasks an FBI agent does.

By mastering surveillance, undercover work, informant handling, interviewing, and lead management, you now have the core field tradecraft down. Next, we'll shift to what happens when all this work comes to a head – making arrests and planning operations, often the most action-packed part of an FBI agent's job.

## Arrests and Operational Planning (SWAT, Raids, and Coordination)

Sooner or later, a case reaches the point of taking action against the suspects – making arrests, conducting search warrants, maybe even raids on hideouts. In the FBI, arrests and raids are treated as operations that require planning and often coordination with specialized teams (like FBI SWAT) and local law enforcement. Here we'll cover how an FBI field agent prepares for and executes these critical moments, ensuring both **safety** and **effectiveness**. Coordination with others is a key theme, be it the FBI's own SWAT team or the local police who know the turf.

### The Arrest Process – From Warrant to Cuffs

**Obtaining an Arrest Warrant:** Generally, before you arrest someone on federal charges, you get a warrant (unless it's an on-the-spot arrest during the commission of a crime or immediate pursuit, etc.). To get an arrest warrant, an FBI agent works with an AUSA to draft a criminal **complaint** or have a grand jury issue an **indictment**. Either way, a judge signs off on a warrant for the person. (Recall: FBI agents do have statutory authority to arrest without a warrant for any federal felony if there's probable cause <sup>67</sup>, but if time allows, a warrant is preferred because it's cleaner legally and tactically – you plan it on your terms). For example, after your bank robbery investigation, you gather enough evidence and the AUSA files a complaint charging John Doe with bank robbery, 18 USC 2113. The Magistrate Judge signs the arrest warrant. Now you're clear to arrest Doe.

**Planning the Arrest:** An arrest plan can range from “grab him next time he's at this predictable public place” to a full-scale dawn raid on a compound. The case agent usually drafts an **Operations Plan** if it's more than a simple nab. The op plan will include: subject info (physical description, criminal history, known weapons?), location (layout of suspect's house perhaps), assignments for each team member (who's arresting agent, who's cover, who handles clearing rooms, who handles evidence collection), coordination signals (what's the cue to breach, etc.), and contingency plans (what if suspect flees or barricades). The plan is reviewed by supervisors, and if SWAT is involved, by the SWAT team leader as well. In the 90s, these might be written in a memo format or a standardized op plan form.

- **Risk Assessment:** Agents consider how dangerous the suspect is. If the person is known armed and violent (say a fugitive with a history of shootouts), FBI will likely use their **SWAT (Special Weapons and Tactics)** team to make the arrest. Every FBI field office in 1997 had a SWAT team composed of agents with extra tactical training. Phoenix, for instance, would have a SWAT contingent to handle high-risk arrests and searches. If SWAT is called, they often take over the immediate tactical plan – using their expertise on entries, use of flashbangs, etc. The case agent still provides intel and stays part of planning, but SWAT leads the charge in execution. If risk is lower (suspect has no violent record, maybe a white-collar criminal), the arrest might be done by case agents themselves with a few extra agents for support, possibly with local police backup if uniform presence is helpful.
- **When and Where to Arrest:** Timing and location are crucial. The safest arrests are often done when the suspect is **in transit** (like in a car) or in a **public, open area** – away from their home base where they might have weapons or defensible positions. One common tactic: perform a vehicle takedown – essentially a traffic stop where agents in unmarked cars (and maybe a marked police unit to lend authority) surround the suspect's car when it's in a convenient spot (like at a stop light or in a parking lot). Another tactic: arrest at the suspect's workplace – often they're unarmed and not expecting it. If the suspect is known to always be at home, then doing an early morning raid (around 5-6 AM) is

standard, catching them hopefully asleep and disoriented. The plan will specify all this: “Arrest to take place at suspect’s residence at 6:00 AM by Team 1; alternate plan if suspect spotted leaving earlier – mobile vehicle stop by Team 2.”

- **Coordination with Locals:** The FBI nearly always informs local law enforcement of an impending operation on their turf. If you’re taking down someone in Phoenix city limits, you inform Phoenix PD or whichever jurisdiction – partly as a courtesy and to avoid blue-on-blue incidents (you don’t want local cops thinking you’re home invaders). Often locals provide support: e.g., uniformed officers to help secure a perimeter, block traffic, or handle crowd control. For a big raid, Phoenix PD might lend a marked car to park visibly down the street – that can deter curious neighbors or at least make them realize it’s police business. Additionally, local paramedics might be alerted to standby a few blocks away (FBI SWAT ops plan always include a medical emergency plan).

For example, if raiding a house in a Phoenix suburb, the FBI might have Phoenix PD SWAT or patrol ready a few blocks out as backup or to take custody if needed. If it’s in a more remote area, maybe county sheriff deputies assist. Inter-agency comity is important: the FBI doesn’t want to be seen as ignoring local authority. And locals appreciate being looped in, plus they know the area (floor plans, where cover might be, etc.).

**Executing the Arrest:** On the day, agents gear up. Standard gear for a warrant execution in 1997 includes: vests (dark blue FBI raid jackets or bulletproof vests marked “FBI”), sidearms and possibly long guns (SWAT will have MP5 submachine guns or M4 rifles; regular agents might have shotguns or just handguns, depending on anticipated resistance), radios with tactical channel (often an FBI channel and one patched to local PD channel if joint), and equipment like breaching tools (battering ram or shotgun breaching rounds) if expecting a forced entry. They also carry the **warrant documents** – one agent will be responsible for having the paper to show or leave at the premises (for a search warrant, you must leave a copy and inventory; for arrest, you have the warrant to show the arrestee if they want).

At the moment of arrest, surprise and speed are key for safety. The team tries to **overwhelm quickly**. If it’s a house raid: “FBI! Warrant!” (the classic shout) as they breach the door after a quick knock-and-announce (unless no-knock is authorized, which by 1997 required special showing, usually they do knock albeit briefly <sup>68</sup>). If it’s grabbing someone in a car: multiple vehicles box them in, agents jump out with guns drawn, identifying “FBI – put your hands up!” In all cases, the objective is to secure the suspect with minimal risk: get them prone or hands visible, handcuff, check for weapons. FBI and police are trained to go **to the ground** – e.g., an agent will pull a suspect out of a car and push them to ground to cuff, because it’s safer than a standing cuffing where they could spin on you.

**Use of Force considerations:** FBI agents follow DOJ Deadly Force Policy, which says they may use deadly force only when necessary to prevent imminent danger of death or serious injury <sup>69</sup> <sup>70</sup>. Practically, agents are taught: **do not shoot unless the suspect poses a lethal threat** (weapon visible or reaching for one). They give verbal commands clearly. If shots are fired, it’s a huge deal – afterwards there will be an investigation. So arrests are ideally done without a trigger pulled. Agents in 1997 know the mantra: “*We don’t shoot to wound; we shoot center mass to stop the threat*” <sup>71</sup> – meaning if forced to fire, they aim for torso to neutralize, not limbs or warning shots (those are against policy). And only if legally justified under the conditions noted (Tennessee v. Garner and such, as referenced in their training <sup>72</sup>).

**After the Arrest – Processing:** Once the suspect is in custody, agents perform a quick **search incident to arrest** – pat them down thoroughly, check pockets, maybe a quick sweep of immediate area for weapons. Any evidence found can be seized (and later documented in a 1A evidence form with chain of custody). For example, you arrest a drug suspect in his living room – you find a pistol in his waistband when cuffing (seize it) and see a bag of cocaine on the coffee table (seize it, since it's in plain view during a lawful arrest sweep). However, more thorough search of the house requires a **search warrant** unless exigent circumstances apply – hopefully you had already obtained a search warrant to execute at the same time, which is common. Often FBI will do dual warrants: an arrest warrant for the person and a search warrant for their residence, executed together in one operation. If so, once suspects are secured, a separate team begins systematically searching the house as per the warrant scope. They photograph the rooms first (if time permits) and then collect evidence, making an inventory (which will be given to the subject or left on premises).

The arrestee is then usually **transported** to either the federal courthouse or a holding facility. FBI itself doesn't have long-term holding cells – typically just short-term holding at the field office or local jail courtesy. In Phoenix, an arrested person might be briefly brought to the FBI office for processing (fingerprinting on an **FD-249 fingerprint card** <sup>73</sup>, and photographing) unless that's done at the U.S. Marshals lockup. Since by law an arrested person must be presented to a magistrate “without unnecessary delay” (usually next business day at latest), timing of arrest matters – agents often do early morning so they can hit the same day's court session. If you arrest at 6am, you can get them to court by the 2pm initial appearance typically. If you arrest at 10pm, you have to hold them overnight (which means coordinating with U.S. Marshals or local PD for a cell).

**Paperwork of an Arrest:** Besides evidence forms, you also do a **custody form** (not listed in those FD forms perhaps because marshals have their own) basically handing the prisoner to U.S. Marshals for holding. And an **FD-302 or FD-209** describing the arrest event itself can be written, especially if notable (like if force was used or evidence seized, document exactly how/where). That is important if, say, the defense later claims excessive force or something was planted – your detailed report soon after carries weight.

**Example – High-Risk Arrest with SWAT:** You have a violent fugitive barricaded in a rural house near Phoenix. He's wanted for multiple armed robberies. Phoenix's FBI SWAT is activated. The plan is to execute a pre-dawn raid. SWAT arrives stealthily around 5am, surrounds the house. You (case agent) are nearby at a command post with local sheriff's reps. At go-time, SWAT uses a loudspeaker: “FBI, come out with your hands up!” – sometimes they'll try call-out to see if suspect surrenders. Suppose he doesn't. They breach the door using a battering ram. They deploy a flashbang grenade (stun device) to disorient him. Entry team moves in with ballistic shields, clearing room to room. The suspect fires a shot at them from a bedroom – a SWAT agent returns fire, wounding him. They subdue and cuff him. Immediately, they shout “Suspect secure, shots fired, subject injured.” You, as case agent, call for the medic (there's usually a paramedic embedded or on standby). The suspect gets first aid and is evacuated to hospital under guard. Meanwhile, you ensure the scene is safe and any other people on site (family, etc.) are okay or also secured. Now this becomes both an arrest scene and potentially a crime scene due to shots fired. FBI Inspection Division and others might later review the shooting, but in the moment, you continue: evidence like the suspect's weapon is preserved, photos taken of bullet holes, etc. You find the cache of stolen goods in a shed (since you also had a search warrant ready). After that, you notify FBI HQ and the DOJ since an agent discharged a firearm (these notifications happen quickly for transparency). The coordination with locals proves useful – the sheriff's deputies keep curious neighbors back and help direct an ambulance in.

That's a dramatic scenario – not everyday, but possible.

**Example – Low-Risk Arrest by Agents:** Now consider a simpler one: You need to arrest a fraud suspect – a 50-year-old accountant charged in a bank fraud scheme. No indication of danger. You and two other agents go to his house at 7AM. You knock, he answers in pyjamas. You show your credentials: “Sir, we’re with the FBI. We have a warrant for your arrest.” Maybe he’s shocked but compliant. You handcuff him (even cooperative folks get cuffed for transport, per policy). You let him grab a jacket and maybe let his wife know what’s happening in basic terms. You search him lightly for any weapons (none). Then you either take him in your car to the federal courthouse cells, or to FBI office first. Many agents prefer straight to court to expedite the process (especially if initial appearance is that day). On the way, you might chat a bit (“Sorry it had to be like this. The charges will be read in court.”) If he starts spontaneously confessing or talking – be cautious: since he wasn’t interrogated per se, anything he says freely is admissible, but you did arrest him so hope you Mirandized him at the time of arrest too (though if he’s chatty without being asked, that’s admissible as spontaneous utterance). Still, to be safe, you had read him his rights at the door or in the car. Many white-collar defendants even have lawyers and will just say nothing beyond cooperating physically.

Once at court, you hand him to Marshals. They handle him from there (fingerprinting, etc., usually done by Marshals pre-court or soon after). You then might testify at his brief initial hearing just to establish identity and that he’s the person named in the warrant. Then bail is set or he’s released on own recognizance if not flight risk. You’ll brief the AUSA on the arrest details.

**Coordination with SWAT specifically:** It’s worth noting, FBI SWAT teams in each division are composed of agents who serve as SWAT on collateral duty (except the elite Hostage Rescue Team which is full-time). So the SWAT guys on your raid might be your buddies from other squads who train each month. They have additional gear like heavy body armor, ballistic helmets, entry tools, etc. If as a case agent you join the entry (maybe as the one to immediately ID the suspect or to start the search once clear), you’d also don a raid jacket or vest, maybe a helmet. But often case agent stays just behind the breach team, not as the first through the door unless they have their own tactical background.

**Arrest Etiquette:** FBI tries to be professional. If family members (like kids) are present, they try to minimize trauma – maybe an agent escorts the kids to another room, or if the suspect is cooperative, let them quietly be taken out without drama. If property is damaged (doors broken), they secure the premises afterwards (like boarding up a door) and note it for possible reimbursement later. These details show the FBI’s consciousness of community impact, especially by the late 90s where community relations were more emphasized than in the gung-ho earlier decades.

## **Planning Searches and Raids – Multi-Agency Operations**

Closely related to arrests is executing **search warrants**, which often happen simultaneously. But let’s broaden to any operation requiring planning beyond a simple arrest – for instance, a coordinated sweep to bust multiple members of a gang at once, or a complex surveillance operation involving aircraft, or a scenario like serving a warrant on a heavily guarded compound (imagine something like the 1996 Montana Freeman standoff – the FBI had to carefully plan that).

**Multi-Target Operations (“Takedowns”):** In cases like organized crime or drug rings, the FBI often will wait and then arrest **all primary suspects nearly simultaneously** to prevent any from warning the others. This is called a **takedown**. Planning a takedown is a project: you might have, say, 10 suspects at different locations around Phoenix and Tucson. You’ll coordinate so that at a set time (often just after dawn for the element of surprise) all teams move in. That requires significant manpower – pulling agents from various

squads, maybe borrowing from other divisions or using SWAT plus regular agents. Each arrest team gets a package with their target's photo, address, any hazards, and the specific charges. A centralized command post (often at the FBI office) will monitor, usually via radio. They might call start: "Execute, execute, execute" at 6:00 AM on the dot. Within minutes, ideally all 10 are in custody. They'll radio status: "Team 3, green – subject in custody" etc. If one suspect is missed (not home or fled), that's noted and pursuit begins. After initial arrests, they may regroup all arrestees at one processing center (like bring everyone to FBI office or the U.S. Marshal lockup). The media might get wind, so the FBI might even have a press release ready if it's a big case (though usually later in day after everyone is secured and charged).

During multi-agency ops, like a joint task force raid, each agency's role is defined. If DEA, ATF, or others join (like in a big drug gang bust), they might each take certain targets or tasks. Often one agency is lead – if it's FBI's case, FBI SAC is in charge overall. But a DEA agent might lead a particular entry team if they knew that suspect well. Interoperability has to be sorted: radio frequencies shared or agents physically grouped with someone who has the right radio to relay communications. In Phoenix, where drug and gang cases might involve DEA and local PD, such coordination is common. They likely have done joint exercises. In 1997, sharing comms was more challenging (no nationwide police radio system). Sometimes the solution is literally to put an FBI agent in the local police helicopter or vice versa, or have each team carry the other's portable radio for cross-talk.

**Use of Specialty Units:** Beyond SWAT, the FBI can call on other specialized units: - **HRT (Hostage Rescue Team):** FBI's national counter-terror SWAT based at Quantico. If something really hairy like a hostage situation beyond field SWAT capability arises, HRT might be deployed via plane. They were used in things like Waco, etc. Not typical for routine ops, only if extraordinary. - **Bomb Techs:** If there's risk of explosives, FBI certified bomb technicians will be part of the plan (Phoenix likely has a few). They have gear like bomb suits, robots. They'd clear a scene if suspicious devices found. - **Negotiators:** If expecting a barricaded suspect or a potential standoff, a negotiation specialist will be assigned. They often try to resolve without bloodshed by talking the suspect out. The op plan will then include negotiator's role and a fallback to tactical entry if talks fail. - **Air Surveillance or Support:** Possibly a helicopter for aerial oversight or to track any fleeing suspects. In Phoenix, maybe a CBP (Customs Border Protection, then called U.S. Customs) helicopter or state DPS helicopter could be requested if FBI doesn't have one locally. The plan might have call-signs for the heli and safe routes to avoid news choppers noticing prematurely. - **Media and deception:** Sometimes they'll do things like schedule arrests to minimize media, or in other cases, deliberately invite media after the fact to show results. Rarely, they might use decoy calls (like calling suspect out under ruse to make arrest easier – e.g., have utility call them outside). Those can be parts of planning too.

**Safety Briefing:** Before any op, there's a briefing (often early morning before stepping off). The plan is reviewed, photos of targets shown, assignments read out. Everyone is reminded of rules of engagement (when to use force, fields of fire, etc.). "If he runs into a school, we're not shooting into a crowd" – those kind of discussions. Also arrest phrase clarity: Identify yourself loud, everyone visibly law enforcement (raid jackets on, etc., to avoid friendly fire). Remember in the chaos of a raid, an FBI agent might only see a figure with a gun – they need to know is that a fellow agent or a bad guy. So, many teams use identifiers like brightly colored FBI markings, or arm bands, etc. They also sometimes have a verbal code if needed – but usually "FBI" shouted and recognized attire suffices. For joint ops, say FBI and DEA, they might all just yell "Police!" generically because shouting multiple acronyms is confusing.

**Post-Operation:** After it's done, a debrief is often held. Any mistakes or lessons (like "we didn't expect that reinforced door – next time bring heavier breacher"). They account for all evidence collected (evidence team

usually goes in after the initial secure, to bag and tag items properly). Write up usage of any force (even pointing a gun at someone might require a notation or at least a mention in report, certainly any discharge or injury does). Then agents might have to pull a long day of processing: interviews of arrestees if they choose to talk, booking paperwork, evidence inventory lists to write, etc. A big morning raid can lead to a full day of paperwork and a long night of writing search warrant return inventories and arrest reports.

**Coordination with Prosecutors:** Usually the AUSA is on standby that morning – if a question arises (like you find additional illegal items not on your warrant), you might call them to quickly get an addendum warrant or advice. E.g. you search for drugs and unexpectedly find a cache of illegal firearms – ATF might be looped in and a new warrant for firearms could be sought, or at least seize under plain view and then add charges. The prosecutor will eventually need a detailed list of what was seized to provide in discovery to defense.

**Example – Coordinated Multi-Arrest:** Phoenix FBI and DEA together take down a meth ring across Arizona. 15 arrest warrants, 10 search warrants. Teams comprised of FBI, DEA agents, plus local PD SWAT for two high-risk sites. At 4:30 AM, all teams assemble at their staging points (different city areas). At 5:00 AM, command post radios “Execute.” Within 10 minutes, at 8 houses, doors are breached and suspects arrested. At 5 of those, evidence searches commence (drugs, records seized). By 6:00 AM, 13 of 15 suspects are in custody; two weren’t home. One of those two is caught later that day by tracking his cell phone (or pager, since 1997 – perhaps he pages someone and agents use that to locate him through the service provider). The last one maybe flees state – an Unlawful Flight warrant is issued. Press releases go out by noon, touting the bust as a victory against drug trafficking. Internally, the SAC congratulates the team but notes one agent twisted an ankle jumping a fence and one suspect’s dog was sadly killed in one raid (common in drug house raids – aggressive guard dogs, which often have to be neutralized; FBI tries to use humane options like tranquilizers but not always possible). That detail may seem minor, but it’s the kind of after-action issue that could cause public complaint (e.g., suspect’s family upset their Rottweiler was shot). The Bureau will review if all was done by the book.

In all of this, an FBI agent’s mindset is **safety first** – protect your team, the public, even the suspect if possible – and **evidence preservation** – don’t let key evidence get destroyed in the heat of action (like someone burning papers as you knock; that’s why speed is key). Operational planning is where the methodical nature of the Bureau shines, as well as its need to work well with others.

By knowing how to plan and execute arrests and searches properly, your role-play can convincingly cover that exciting climax of many cases. But the story doesn’t end with cuffing the bad guy; next comes working with prosecutors and stepping into the courtroom – where an agent’s work is scrutinized under oath. We address that next.

## Working with Other Agencies and Partners

No FBI agent is an island. In virtually every investigation, FBI agents collaborate with a web of other law enforcement bodies – from local police and sheriffs to federal partners like the DEA, ATF, INS (Immigration and Naturalization Service, as it was called in 1997), U.S. Marshals, and of course the U.S. Attorney’s Office for prosecutions. Understanding these relationships is crucial to portraying an FBI agent who knows how to leverage resources and navigate jurisdictional boundaries.

## Local Law Enforcement (Police, Sheriffs)

**Philosophy of Cooperation:** The FBI in 1997 operates on the principle that good relationships with local law enforcement are essential. While historically (especially under Hoover) there were rivalries, by the 90s the culture is largely collegial. FBI has things locals want (e.g., lab resources, federal jurisdiction for big cases) and locals have things FBI needs (street-level intel, uniform presence, local legal knowledge). As an agent, you'd maintain contacts at local PD. Phoenix Division agents would frequently liaise with Phoenix Police Department (PPD) detectives, county sheriffs (Maricopa County Sheriff for Phoenix area, plus others statewide for RAs).

**Task Forces:** A major form of cooperation is joint **task forces**. For example, Phoenix had (and still has) an FBI-led **Violent Crime Task Force** where local PD detectives and FBI agents work together on bank robberies, kidnappings, and the like. There was also likely a **Drug Task Force** or Safe Streets Task Force combining FBI, DEA, and local narcotics units <sup>74</sup>. By 1997, **Joint Terrorism Task Forces (JTTFs)** were starting to form in many divisions (post-OKC bombing era), which include local officers and FBI agents focusing on terrorism <sup>75</sup>. If your character is on one of these, they might have a city detective as a partner or even be co-located at a local police building.

**Jurisdictional Issues:** Local police handle state crimes; FBI handles federal. But often the distinction blurs. Take a bank robbery: it's both a state crime (armed robbery) and a federal crime (bank robbery federal statute). Usually, the FBI and local PD will decide who leads. In many cases, especially in the 90s where bank robberies were rampant, Phoenix PD might initially respond, secure the scene, then call FBI. The FBI often takes lead if the suspects are likely serials or cross jurisdictions. Minor robberies might be left to locals if FBI resources are thin, but since bank robbery was a federal priority in the '90s <sup>76</sup>, FBI Phoenix would pick them up. The local detectives might still be involved – often as task force members or liaison. They might even be deputized as federal Task Force Officers (TFOs) so they can act under federal law.

Another example: A murder – normally state crime; FBI has no jurisdiction unless, say, it happened on federal land or is part of a federal case. But FBI might assist locals with forensics (bringing in FBI Evidence Response Team or lab help if asked). If local cops suspect a serial killer crossing state lines, FBI gets involved (ViCAP program or BAU help). It's a dance of who has jurisdiction versus who has expertise. As an FBI agent, your character would be mindful not to “bigfoot” locals – i.e., not try to take over just for ego. This is a known point of tension in some places. The Phoenix FBI history shows instances of cooperative big cases, e.g., joining hundreds of officers in a major gang raid <sup>77</sup> or working corruption cases that locals couldn't internally handle <sup>78</sup>. So emphasize teamwork: inviting a local detective to help interview a suspect, sharing intel with a city gang unit about impending violence, etc.

**Police Support in FBI Ops:** We covered some – perimeter security, marked units for visibility, using local SWAT if needed (some cities have excellent SWAT teams and FBI might defer to them on their turf, or integrate them with FBI SWAT). Also, locals often handle immediate 911 calls. For instance, if an FBI surveillance sees a fugitive but a local patrol is closer, they might radio the local dispatcher to send a unit for a traffic stop – then the FBI rolls in to ID and take custody. That avoids suspects recognizing an FBI tail and bolting.

**Cultural and Info Sharing:** FBI agents might attend local PD roll-call meetings occasionally or vice versa. Many FBI agents are former local cops, which helps camaraderie. In Phoenix, post-1993 (after a certain famous case of a Phoenix memo that wasn't shared before 9/11, cooperation in intel improved – though

that's after our time frame, but seeds were there). In 1997, **information sharing** is done through personal contacts and formal channels (like NCIC and state crime databases). If Phoenix PD arrests someone and finds they might be of interest to FBI (e.g., they find explosives – local cops will notify FBI bomb squad), they call up the FBI duty agent or squad supervisor. Conversely, FBI might brief locals if a wanted fed suspect is believed hiding locally, so locals can help look out (and they might issue a BOLO through local channels).

**Example – Working with Phoenix PD:** Suppose you're investigating a series of armored car heists (federal because it affects commerce and often there's federal insurance, etc.). Phoenix PD had initial response to one such robbery and are running their own investigation. You reach out to the PD detective: "Hey, let's combine forces – you know the streets, we can add federal resources." You form a joint task force. Now you share leads openly. You maybe sit in the city's robbery unit office a day or two a week and they have a detective sit in your FBI squad. You run federal grand jury subpoenas for phone records that the PD would otherwise need a state warrant for – saving time. They put you in touch with a street informant who has gang contacts, who ends up becoming an FBI informant with the detective as a co-handler. When it comes time to arrest, both FBI and PD SWAT work together, and both federal and state charges are possible. In fact, maybe the US Attorney and County Attorney discuss and decide to go federal for stronger penalties (common with armed robbery if they want heavier time). But sometimes they might go state if the state penalties are adequate and it eases the process. Either way, you as the FBI agent try to ensure the local detective gets credit too (maybe even cross-designation so he can testify in federal court). When speaking to the press, the FBI SAC and the Police Chief might do a joint press conference, each praising the partnership. That's good politics and fosters trust.

**Deconfliction:** This is a modern buzzword but relevant. It means making sure two agencies aren't unknowingly investigating or going after the same target and end up colliding. In 1997, this was done mostly by communication – agents and detectives talk to each other about ongoing cases if appropriate. For example, you might ask the local intel unit "Any of your guys working a suspect named X? We have him on our radar." There were also multi-agency centers (e.g., **HIDTA - High Intensity Drug Trafficking Area** centers) where different agencies share info on drug targets. Phoenix likely was part of a Southwest Border HIDTA program. Part of an FBI agent's job is to check those and coordinate with DEA or locals to avoid duplication or screw-ups.

### **Federal Partners: DEA, ATF, INS, Marshals, etc.**

Each federal agency has its niche, but overlaps do occur. Key ones in 1997:

- **DEA (Drug Enforcement Administration):** DEA leads federal drug trafficking investigations. FBI also had authority over drug crimes, especially in connection to organized crime or gangs (and had Safe Streets Task Forces focusing on drug gangs). Typically, FBI and DEA have a somewhat competitive but collaborative relationship. A rule of thumb: international or large interstate drug cartel -> DEA (with FBI possibly assisting on money laundering aspects); drug gangs that are part of broader criminal enterprise -> could be FBI. In Phoenix, heavy drug trafficking from the border might see both DEA and FBI working parallel. They often form **joint task forces** (with IRS too for finances). The DOJ tries to avoid duplication by having them coordinate – sometimes one agency will step back if the other already has the case. Agents might poke fun at each other (culture: DEA seen as more gung-ho "door kickers" for drugs, FBI as broader-scope investigators). But on the ground, they swap intel. Example: DEA might tell FBI if they hear one of their targets is also planning a bombing

(beyond DEA scope – that becomes FBI's terror case). FBI might tell DEA if an informant of theirs mentions a big drug deal beyond FBI's current case.

- **ATF (Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, and Firearms):** In '97, ATF handled federal firearms violations (illegal gun sales, felon in possession, etc.), explosives, and arson cases (especially non-terror ones). There's overlap: a bomb used by a domestic terrorist might be FBI or ATF or both. Post-Oklahoma City, the DOJ gave FBI lead on terrorism cases, even those involving bombs, but ATF still has huge expertise in bomb forensics and arson investigation. Often they'd form **joint bomb task forces** for serial bombings (FBI brings intel, ATF brings explosives know-how). For example, in Phoenix, if there were a string of church arsons, ATF and FBI would likely work together (civil rights + arson). Culturally, some rivalry existed (Waco siege in '93 was an ATF operation that went bad and FBI had to take over – that was a learning moment). But generally, by '97 they cooperated, dividing roles: ATF might take lead on tracing firearms found in an FBI case (they run the gun tracing center). If FBI finds a weapons trafficking ring, they might ask ATF to join because ATF can pursue additional gun charges. Likewise, ATF might ask FBI for help if their case involves complex interstate conspiracy the FBI's RICO statutes could hammer.

As an agent, you might coordinate with ATF agents in Phoenix by, say, attending the monthly **ATF explosives task force meeting** or simply calling your ATF liaison about any gun or bomb evidence. For instance, if you recover a gun at a crime scene, you'd send it to ATF's National Tracing Center to see where it was purchased. If you have ballistic evidence, ATF's NIBIN database (ballistics imaging) might link casings to other crimes <sup>79</sup>. So you'd either use ATF's system or FBI lab's, but often ATF pioneered ballistics databasing. Mentioning sharing that resource adds realism.

- **INS (Immigration and Naturalization Service):** In 1997, INS handled immigration law enforcement (pre-ICE days). Phoenix being near Mexico means immigration issues are present (e.g., smuggling of people, document fraud, etc.). FBI typically doesn't enforce immigration law per se, but if an FBI case involves non-citizens, they coordinate with INS. Example: You arrest a suspect and find out he's an illegal immigrant – the FBI might prosecute for the main crime, and let INS initiate deportation proceedings concurrently or after. Or, FBI might leverage INS status: threaten a mob informant with deportation if he doesn't cooperate (with INS coordination, since FBI can't deport someone but can ask INS to begin process). Another scenario: Investigating a human trafficking ring, FBI and INS often work together (INS had investigators focusing on that). On joint operations, INS agents might handle the processing of any undocumented immigrants found, while FBI handles criminal aspects like if there's a kidnapping element.

In Phoenix, INS would also be key if working cross-border crime; e.g., checking entries/exits of suspects (INS can look up if John Doe crossed the border at Nogales recently). So an FBI agent might phone the INS duty officer to get a **TECS** query (Treasury Enforcement Communications System, which INS/Customs used to log border crossings). Or send an **INS Lookout (FD-315)** to flag a suspect in INS's system <sup>80</sup> – meaning if that person tries to enter or exit US, INS will detain and notify FBI. That form is specifically mentioned <sup>80</sup>. Using that is good flavor: "We put a lookout on the suspect with INS, so if he tries to fly internationally or cross at Mexico, we'll know <sup>80</sup>."

- **U.S. Marshals Service:** Marshals have a few intersections with FBI. One, they run the federal courts' security and handle prisoners. After you arrest someone, Marshals take custody for pre-trial detention. So an FBI agent frequently deals with Marshals at the courthouse or cellblock. Two,

Marshals lead on fugitive manhunts for federal fugitives (someone who fled after being charged, or escaped custody). FBI also has authority for fugitives (especially if across state lines – Unlawful Flight to Avoid Prosecution warrants), but often the agencies coordinate. In the 90s, Marshals had regional fugitive task forces. If your suspect flees, FBI might get a **UFAP warrant** and then Marshals or a local fugitive task force actually tracks him while you focus on the rest of case. In role-play, if a bad guy runs, your FBI agent would likely call the Marshals and input the person into NCIC as wanted. Marshals also run Witness Security (WITSEC). If you have a high-value witness needing protection, FBI works with Marshals to relocate them, give new IDs, etc. The FBI agent still handles the investigation, but Marshals are bodyguards/relocators. This can be some inter-agency drama if not careful – the Marshals might want the witness off the grid, while FBI might want to use them to lure out suspects.

- **U.S. Attorney's Office (AUSAs):** Though not a law enforcement agency in the same sense, the relationship with federal prosecutors is one of the most important partnerships. We'll cover courtroom specifics in the next section, but in investigation phase: AUSAs are legal advisors and decision-makers on charges. An FBI agent typically consults the AUSA at critical junctures: when seeking warrants (they review affidavits), when deciding charges (they might prefer a certain charge because it's easier to prove or carries a better sentence), and when legal issues arise (like "Can we legally do X under the 4th Amendment here?" – the AUSA guides or suggests how to proceed). In Phoenix, the U.S. Attorney's Office would have divisions for criminal prosecutions (narcotics, white-collar, etc.), and likely specific AUSAs assigned as liaisons to FBI squads. For example, one AUSA might be the point for the Violent Crime Squad, meeting with them weekly to discuss case status. As an agent, building a good rapport with "your AUSA" is vital. You want them to trust your work so they will go to bat in court with confidence in your evidence.

**Example – Federal Partnership in a Gun Case:** Let's say the Phoenix FBI gets a tip about a group selling stolen guns. That could be FBI or ATF. Perhaps both join forces: FBI brings an informant who can do a sting buy, ATF brings expertise in tracing the guns and knowledge of firearms laws. Together, they plan a bust. FBI's undercover buys some guns illegally; ATF agents surveil to ID suppliers. When bust day comes, both FBI and ATF agents make the arrests. Legally, the case could be charged under federal gun statutes (18 USC §922, etc.) which ATF agents are extremely familiar with, so an ATF agent might be the lead witness in court for technical gun evidence, whereas the FBI agent might testify about the informant handling or conspiracy evidence. They coordinate with an AUSA who maybe specializes in gun trafficking. Post-arrest, ATF handles the tracing of each gun's origin (to show they were stolen or crossed state lines, establishing federal nexus), FBI handles tying the suspects to other crimes perhaps. They would share credit in any press release, and internally, probably send each other attaboys.

**Example – Border/Immigration Issue:** FBI Phoenix has a case of a fugitive who might flee to Mexico. INS and U.S. Customs are involved at the border. The FBI agent requests an INS lookout <sup>80</sup> and also notifies the **Legat (Legal Attaché)** in Mexico City (the FBI's representative abroad) to liaise with Mexican authorities if needed. Meanwhile, U.S. Customs (which in '97 is separate from INS, dealing with contraband at borders) might help by watching for the fugitive's car at crossings or using their intelligence network. Once the guy is caught in Mexico, extradition is a whole other process – FBI and the U.S. Attorney work through DOJ's Office of International Affairs. But that's a bit deep; just noting, an FBI agent might have to work with foreign counterparts too, often via those Legat offices.

**Case Study – Inter-agency success (hypothetical):** In 1997, a series of bombings occurs on federal land in Arizona (maybe environmental extremists – which did happen, like the “EMETIC” case mentioned in Phoenix history <sup>81</sup>). FBI leads as domestic terrorism, but ATF helps with bomb forensics, and the Forest Service law enforcement might be involved since it’s on their land, plus local police for initial response. They form a task force. After painstaking investigation (surveillance, informants, etc.), they identify the culprits, who are hiding in a compound. The arrest involves FBI SWAT, ATF agents, and local deputies. Evidence seized goes partly to FBI lab (for hair, fiber, etc.) and partly to ATF lab (for explosive residue analysis). In court, both FBI and ATF personnel testify – FBI about the conspiracy and investigation, ATF about how the bomb was made and matched evidence. The joint effort is cited as crucial in bringing the perpetrators to justice <sup>81</sup>.

When role-playing, inter-agency stuff can create interesting scenarios – sometimes tension (differing priorities, or turf battles) or sometimes great backup (calling in a favor from a buddy at DEA for urgent info). It’s realistic for your agent to sometimes chafe at another agency’s bureaucracy (“Ugh, INS is taking forever to respond to that query”) or to express gratitude (“Tucson PD really saved our behinds on that surveillance, giving us a helicopter unit”). Just avoid a lone-wolf mindset; FBI agents know they need partnerships to succeed.

**Mindset and Respect:** FBI agents in the field in 1997 often consider themselves the “quarterback” when it’s their case, but they also know each agency has authority. For example, if a case could be charged either state or federal, sometimes they let locals take it if more appropriate (especially if the federal penalties are not significantly different). A savvy agent might say: “We can make this carjacking a federal case (since it crossed state lines), but the county DA already has him on a murder charge that will put him away for life, so maybe we let that proceed and not complicate with dual prosecutions.” That shows understanding of the bigger picture – not just chasing stats.

In summation, inter-agency cooperation is the lifeblood of effective law enforcement. Your FBI character should be depicted as someone who can pick up a phone and talk with a city detective one minute, coordinate a plan with a DEA squad leader the next, and then advise an AUSA on evidence for trial – all in a day’s work. It’s challenging but ultimately rewarding when the “good guys” present a united front.

## Courtroom Preparation and Testimony

Arrests and raids might feel like the climax of a case, but in truth, an FBI agent’s job continues into the courtroom. The evidence collected and the actions taken have to hold up under legal scrutiny, and agents often serve as witnesses in trials. Additionally, preparing the case with prosecutors to ensure a successful prosecution is a major responsibility. We’ll break this down into two parts: **(1) Case Prep with Prosecutors and Pre-Trial Process**, and **(2) Testifying in Court**.

### Working with Prosecutors and Pre-Trial Preparation

**Case Handover to AUSA:** After an arrest or indictment, a federal prosecutor (Assistant U.S. Attorney, AUSA) takes charge of the legal case, but they rely heavily on the agent (case agent) to marshal the evidence. Early on, you’ll meet with the AUSA to review what you have. This might involve sitting down and going through the case file in detail: all the 302s, photographs, physical evidence, etc. The AUSA will identify what else might be needed for trial – e.g., “We need a summary chart of those bank records” or “Can you get an expert to analyze this device?” The case agent essentially becomes the **liaison** between the legal process and the investigative team.

**Indictment & Grand Jury:** Many federal cases go to a grand jury for indictment (unless they pled out early). The agent often testifies in the grand jury as well, in a less formal way (no judge or defense, just jurors and prosecutor). It's one-sided, meant to establish probable cause for formal charges. The agent might narrate the investigation in summary. Grand jury testimony is secret (in the U.S., revealing it is a crime), so the agent must be careful not to discuss it elsewhere. However, anything said there could later be used for cross-examination if inconsistent with trial testimony, so agents prepare for grand jury thoroughly to be accurate <sup>82</sup>.

**Discovery Obligations:** The prosecution must turn over evidence to the defense – especially anything exculpatory (Brady rule) and prior statements of witnesses (Jencks Act) <sup>83</sup>. The agent helps gather and organize this. In practice, you as case agent work with a paralegal at the USAO to compile a **discovery package**: copies of all reports, recordings, photos, etc. Some things might be withheld or redacted for protective reasons (like informant identities, until appropriate). But by trial, if an informant is testifying, their identity and any deals would be disclosed <sup>51</sup>. Agents ensure that no evidence is hidden in their trunk or something – it all needs to be accounted for. A thorough agent will have cataloged evidence and reports such that nothing “surprises” the prosecutor last-minute. In role-play, you could show your character double-checking: “I review our files to make sure we’ve turned over every relevant report to the AUSA – I know the defense will get our 302s once we testify <sup>83</sup>, so they need to be in order.”

**Motions and Legal Meetings:** Defense attorneys often file motions: to suppress evidence (claiming some search was illegal), to disclose informants, etc. The agent plays a big role in responding to these. For a suppression hearing (e.g., to challenge a search warrant's validity or a confession's voluntariness), the agent will likely testify to explain how they obtained evidence – basically a mini-trial on legality. The AUSA will prep the agent for this: “They’ll ask if you really knocked and announced” or “Be ready to explain how you Mirandized him.” The agent's earlier good work and documentation is crucial here. If an agent cut corners, a judge might suppress evidence. For example, if a defense claims the agent didn't properly advise of rights, the agent's testimony plus that signed FD-395 form <sup>61</sup> will refute it.

**Trial Preparation with AUSA:** As trial nears, the agent works with the prosecutor to map out how to present the case. They decide which witnesses to call in what order, which exhibits to introduce, etc. The agent often has a big picture of the case, so the AUSA might rely on them to ensure nothing is overlooked. There may be **prep sessions** where the agent and AUSA review the expected testimonies of various witnesses (“We need to emphasize that detail from the victim's story”). Sometimes the agent writes a **Prosecutive Summary** (a distilled narrative of the case) to help the AUSA catch up or for internal use <sup>84</sup>. If the case is complex, they might prepare visual aids – charts of the conspiracy, timelines, etc., often with agent input or even made by the agent (some agents excel at PowerPoint, others get FBI analysts to assist).

Additionally, the agent ensures physical evidence is ready for court: every item might need a label, chain of custody established, possibly lab experts to testify about it. The case agent coordinates those experts (FBI lab examiners, etc., making sure they're available and have provided reports to defense). For instance, if fingerprints were lifted from a scene, the FBI fingerprint analyst will need to testify to that. You as case agent might help the AUSA arrange that witness's travel and get them the proper exhibits (like the latent print cards and comparison charts).

**Witness Management:** The agent often also plays the role of **witness coordinator** for other witnesses like victims, informants, or local officers. You keep them informed of trial dates, prep them on what to expect (without coaching them to change story, just procedural prep). The FBI also has a Victim-Witness program,

so victims might have a separate liaison, but case agents still often are involved in making sure victims are ready for court and comfortable.

**Case Agent at Trial:** During trial, it's common for the case agent to sit at the prosecution table with the AUSA <sup>85</sup> (provided they're not the very next witness; usually after the agent testifies, they can remain in the courtroom, since witnesses are often "sequestered" until after their testimony to prevent hearing others' testimony). The agent's there to assist with facts (quietly reminding the AUSA of a detail), to manage exhibits ("Agent, please retrieve Exhibit 12 from the evidence case"), and to be available if something breaks (say a new evidence issue arises mid-trial, the agent might have to go find a record or make a phone call during a recess). This role is often called the **"case agent" role at counsel table** <sup>59</sup>.

**Plea Bargains and Sentencing:** Many cases plead out before trial. The agent's work then is to help the AUSA get the defendant to proffer (if required) and to provide info for sentencing. Federal sentences use guidelines – agents sometimes submit to the probation office a summary of the case or evidence of additional relevant behavior to influence the guideline range <sup>86</sup> <sup>87</sup>. For example, if the guy had a gun during the crime, the agent ensures the prosecutor knows to ask for the enhancement (18 USC 924(c) or guideline bump) <sup>88</sup> <sup>89</sup>. The agent might also attend the sentencing hearing (not to testify, but as presence, and in case the judge asks something obscure).

**Paperwork During Trial:** As each witness testifies, any prior statements (like 302s) that relate must be given to defense (Jencks) <sup>83</sup>. The AUSA might have the case agent handle that: e.g., after a witness is done on direct exam, during the break the case agent hands the defense attorney the 302 of that witness. If there's something in it the defense can use to impeach (like a small discrepancy), they will. But that's expected. The agent should have made sure the witness reviewed their 302 before – FBI practice is often to refresh witnesses with their statements pre-trial to ensure they remember and to correct any mistakes.

## Testifying in Court – "On the Stand"

Now to the spotlight moment – your agent character on the witness stand, under oath. Here's how agents approach testimony:

**Professional Demeanor:** Agents appear in court in professional attire (suit and tie for men, equivalent for women). Firearms are typically not worn in visible court; often agents check their gun or conceal it deeply (some courthouses require law enforcement to secure weapons). They address the judge as "Your Honor," the attorneys as "Mr./Ms. so-and-so." They must project confidence, honesty, and neutrality. A good agent witness doesn't get snarky or combative, even under provocation by defense. They answer clearly, calmly, and succinctly, sticking to facts. Juries often find agents credible, so maintaining that trust is key.

**Direct Examination (Prosecutor questioning):** The AUSA will guide the agent through testimony. Usually starts with background: "State your name and occupation." Then some credentials if relevant ("I have been an FBI agent for 7 years, assigned to violent crime squad, etc."). Sometimes the defense will stipulate to the agent's expertise if they're giving expert-like opinions (like an FBI agent testifying about how a drug ring operates might be qualified as an expert witness in drug trafficking). Next, the AUSA will have the agent describe aspects of the investigation: depending on what's needed – maybe how evidence was collected, or if the agent is the summary witness, they'll provide the narrative of the whole case tying all evidence together <sup>90</sup>. For example, the AUSA might ask: "What did you do next in your investigation?" repeatedly to get chronological story. The agent should avoid hearsay unless it falls under an exception or is not offered

for truth. (Tricky part: if agent tries to say "An informant told me X," that's hearsay if to prove X; usually not allowed unless a hearsay exception applies or it's to explain why agent took next step – that second reason is allowed but delicate. Prosecutors often instruct agents to avoid recounting informant tips in detail on the stand; they focus on what the investigation found as evidence.)

The AUSA will also introduce exhibits through the agent. "Agent, I show you Government Exhibit 12 (a photograph). Do you recognize this?" Agent: "Yes, that's the getaway car we found." "How do you recognize it?" – "I towed it to our lot and the license plate matches records." – "Your Honor, move to admit Exhibit 12." Judge says ok, then AUSA publishes to jury (shows them). The agent might then explain the significance: "We found a bag with \5,000 in the trunk of that car." Each piece like that gets in via some witness, often the agent who collected it or witnessed it <sup>63</sup>.

Agents might also testify about confessions: "What did the defendant tell you after arrest?" This is crucial – the agent needs to recount the Miranda waiver ("I advised him of his rights and he agreed to talk" – established voluntariness) and then exactly what was said. They typically refer to their 302 to refresh memory if needed (allowed if they can't recall verbatim and they wrote it when fresh). But better is to remember the key lines. In giving a confession in testimony, they often couch it as, "He stated, and I quote, 'I was just the lookout, I didn't go inside the bank,' end quote." They try to be precise so defense can't nitpick that the agent put words in the defendant's mouth differently than what he said.

**Cross-Examination (Defense questioning):** This is where the defense attorney tries to find inconsistencies, cast doubt, or get concessions. Common tactics on agents: - **Impeach with prior statements:** If the agent's testimony differs in any detail from their reports or prior hearing, the defense will point it out. Example: "Agent, in your report you wrote the suspect's jacket was blue, but today you said it was black. Which is it?" Even tiny things are used to say "see, they can be wrong." An agent's response should be honest: "If my report says blue, then I defer to what I recorded at the time. It may have been dark; it appeared black to me today but could be dark blue." Basically, don't get flustered, just address it reasonably. - **Accuse of Poor Procedure:** Defense might ask, "You didn't record the interrogation, did you?" expecting no – "So the jury only has your word for what was said." The agent would respond truthfully, perhaps adding "FBI procedure at that time was to summarize in a written report <sup>63</sup>, which I did promptly." If asked why not record: agent can't say "because we find we get more confessions without it" (even if that's partly true), they usually say "It's just not our standard practice, and I ensured accuracy by taking detailed notes." The legal handbook notes defense often attacked lack of recordings <sup>63</sup>. - **Bias or personal stake:** "You consider this case a success if Mr. Doe is convicted, right?" – trying to show bias or that agent might slant things. An agent might answer, "My job is to find the truth. If he's convicted on truthful evidence, that's justice. If evidence showed he was innocent, I'd report that too." Something along those lines to diffuse bias argument. - **Informant deals or misconduct:** If an informant was used, defense will grill if they were paid or promised leniency <sup>51</sup>. The agent must admit payments if any (and they will have been disclosed). They might say "Yes, we paid CI #123 \5,000 for information over 6 months <sup>55</sup>, and that was disclosed. We also informed the prosecutor of his own pending charges." Basically, show nothing to hide. - **Constitutional adherence:** They may ask about search warrant details, hoping to find a misstep. If an agent conducted a search, the defense might challenge the warrant scope: "The warrant was for drugs, but you also seized cash – that wasn't listed, was it?" The agent can point out it's common to seize proceeds of crime or that the cash was found with the drugs, etc., and that it was itemized later and approved by a judge post hoc. They try to avoid any concession of an illegal search. If a search was borderline, often that would have been fought in a pre-trial suppression hearing rather than in front of the jury, but sometimes minor points come up.

**Staying Composed:** The cardinal rule for agents on cross: **don't lose your cool**. Defense attorneys may be friendly or may be aggressive, even accusatory ("Agent, did you fabricate that entire confession?"). The agent should calmly respond, "No, I did not." If an agent doesn't know or remember something, they should say so rather than guess or lie – honesty is paramount. That might mean admitting a gap ("I don't recall that detail at the moment" or "I'd have to refer to document X to answer accurately").

**Addressing the Jury:** Technically, witnesses answer to the questioner, but effectively they are communicating to the jury. Good agent witnesses make eye contact with jurors occasionally, especially on important points, to be engaging and clear. But they must do so in a way that's sincere, not theatrical. FBI training often includes some pointers on testifying, and by late 90s most agents had been through at least a mock trial in training and some real hearings.

**Special Situations:** If the trial involves classified info (rare in 90s Phoenix unless espionage or certain national security cases), there's a whole CIPA (Classified Information Procedures Act) process to avoid disclosing secrets – beyond our scope but an agent might have to testify in a closed session or with codewords. Another scenario: **expert testimony**. Sometimes agents testify as experts on things like drug values, gang terminology, etc. Then their qualifications are established and they can give opinion. The handling on stand is slightly different (can say "In my expert opinion, the markings on the weapon indicate it's a machinegun" etc.). But that's more common with ATF agents or analysts.

**After Testimony:** Once an agent is done, they might remain in court to watch the rest if allowed (often case agent is allowed to stay even if not testified yet under a case agent exception to witness sequestration rules). If the agent hasn't testified yet, they may be excluded from the courtroom during other testimony to keep their testimony untainted by hearing others (typical witness sequestration rule). Usually the case agent testifies either first (to set scene) or last (to summarize and tie together evidence) <sup>90</sup>, depending on strategy. If last, they get to address anything that came up as confusion – kind of like the prosecution's closer.

**Verdict and Post-Trial:** Agents anxiously await verdicts too. They may sit behind the AUSA as the jury reads it. If "Guilty," there's often a silent fist clench of relief. If "Not Guilty," it's a blow – though professional agents won't show outrage; they accept it and move on, maybe discussing with AUSA later what went wrong (lack of certain evidence, juror attitudes, etc.). After trial, some agents meet jurors who are willing to talk (if acquitted especially, to learn). FBI actually values those insights to improve. If convicted, at sentencing sometimes agents or victims give statements, but usually not agents (unless asked a factual question). The case agent's final duty might be to attend sentencing or to handle any appeals inquiries (sometimes appeals require going over the case again with appellate attorneys, though agents seldom involved heavily in appeals unless a retrial happens).

**Example – Court Sequence:** Imagine your bank robbery case goes to trial. The eyewitness teller testifies about the robbery, the getaway driver (who flipped) testifies against the defendant as cooperating witness, a forensic expert ties the defendant via DNA on a mask found, etc. Then you, the case agent, testify last to wrap it up: you recount how you arrested the defendant, his post-arrest confession where he admitted being the robber (the highlight). On cross, defense tries to say you pressured him into confessing or that he was under duress. You answer how he was treated well, given water, and freely talked after understanding his rights (and you have his signed waiver to prove it). The defense also points out maybe that you didn't fingerprint the getaway car (implying sloppy work). You acknowledge, "No, we did not lift prints from the car, as we already had sufficient evidence linking it to Mr. Doe and focused resources on other aspects."

That's a reasonable answer; sometimes admitting a non-action with a rationale is better than being defensive. After both sides rest, you sit with AUSA as they do closing arguments. Jury convicts. After, some jurors tell the AUSA they found the FBI witnesses very credible, which was decisive. That's a proud moment for the team.

**Protocol and Etiquette in Court for Agents:** One interesting tidbit: Agents usually are addressed as "Agent [Surname]" in court by counsel and judge. They answer "Yes, sir/ma'am" often. They also have to follow rulings: if an objection is sustained, they stop mid-sentence and wait for next question – discipline is key. If they don't understand a question, they can ask for clarification rather than flub an answer.

**Contempt and Mistakes:** If an agent ever did something improper on the stand (like blurting out excluded evidence), the judge might scold them or even declare a mistrial. FBI agents are trained to avoid that; they listen carefully to objections and will pause if one is made. If a judge says "strike that from the record," the agent cannot refer to it again.

**Subpoenas for Agents:** Sometimes defense might subpoena FBI records or even call an FBI agent as a defense witness (if they think that agent's info helps them). That can be awkward, but the FBI has attorneys to handle such issues. Usually the case agent won't become a defense witness unless something like they had exculpatory evidence (rare scenario, since that would have been surfaced via prosecution if it existed, per Brady).

**Aftermath:** Once trial is truly over (including appeals if any, though appeals are mostly lawyers), the agent's work turns to maybe tying up administrative ends: returning evidence to rightful owners, disposing of seized contraband (per court order), closing out informant files related to the case, and writing a final **closing communication** to FBIHQ summarizing the outcome (HQ often requires a summary of significant convictions for their records). For example, an **FD-515 Accomplishment Report** might be submitted noting the conviction <sup>29</sup>.

In role-play, the courtroom scene can be dramatic. You'd want to capture the flavor of an agent under oath explaining things methodically and deflecting the defense's arrows politely. It's the test of all the work that came before. Sometimes agents privately feel more nervous in court than doing an arrest, because their reputation and the case outcome are on the line in a forum out of their direct control. Demonstrating a bit of that human side (sweaty palms when tough cross comes, a sense of relief when done) can add realism.

To conclude, being an FBI agent means seeing a case through to *justice*, not just to *arrest*. And justice in the system means presenting evidence fairly and strongly so that the truth prevails in court. By guiding the role-play through these courtroom steps, you ensure the story doesn't stop at the squad room but goes all the way to verdict, reflecting the real journey of an FBI investigation.

## Internal FBI Culture and Conduct Expectations

Beyond the procedures and action, an FBI agent's life in 1997 is governed by a set of cultural norms and internal rules. These cover everything from how you dress and carry your weapon, to the hours you keep, how you handle your cases, and even what you do on your own time. Portraying these correctly adds authenticity to your character. Let's explore these aspects:

## Dress Code and Appearance

**Professional Attire:** In the late 90s, FBI agents were typically expected to dress in professional business attire for most duties, especially when interacting with the public or other agencies. For men, that generally meant a suit or at least a dress shirt, tie, and slacks. For women, a suit or equivalent professional outfit. The image of the FBI “G-man” in a suit was still alive and well. That said, allowances were made for specific assignments: an agent on surveillance or doing a raid might wear jeans, a t-shirt, and a raid jacket; an undercover agent would dress appropriate to their role; an evidence tech at a messy scene might wear coveralls. But the default at the field office daily would be more formal.

Phoenix’s climate (hot much of the year) might have some effect – perhaps coats come off when in the office, shirt sleeves allowed. But if going to court or an interview, they’d put the coat on (or at least tie). FBI also had grooming standards: neat haircuts (no extremely long hair or outrageous styles; by 90s mustaches were okay, beards less common except in undercover roles), no visible tattoos usually (agents would cover them if they had any). For women, conservative hair and jewelry – nothing that would stand out too much. The goal was an appearance that commands respect and doesn’t draw negative attention.

Agents also had a knack for blending. For instance, if doing a street canvas, an agent might tone down – sport shirt and khakis to seem approachable rather than intimidating. But they’d still flash the FBI credentials and be polite. The FBI creds themselves: a leather fold with a badge and ID. Agents carry it and their badge often on belt or in a pocket, ready to show.

**The FBI “look”:** There was (and is) a bit of a stereotype – the dark suit, white shirt, subdued tie, shiny shoes, and a stern but polite face. Many agents adhered to that, at least when the situation demanded. On raids, they throw on the dark blue FBI windbreaker with large yellow letters – that iconic look was in use since the 80s and still common in ’97. If an agent had court, you bet they shine their shoes and have a well-pressed suit. They know juries and judges notice. Internally, an agent who dresses sloppy might get a friendly ribbing or a direct “straighten up” from a supervisor.

So in role-play, if your scene is the office in morning, you might note “Agent Smith comes in wearing a crisp white shirt and navy tie, coffee in hand.” If they are about to do an arrest: “She changes into jeans and a polo, throwing her FBI raid jacket on over it.” At a formal meeting or press conference: “He’s back in suit and tie, hat off (90s agents didn’t wear hats routinely, aside from maybe ballcaps on ops).”

**Firearms and Gear Appearance:** Firearms are part of attire too. Standard issue in 1997 was a Glock 22 or 23 (.40 caliber) pistol <sup>91</sup>. Agents typically carry it on their belt holster, usually concealed under the jacket (FBI agents generally carry concealed unless in raid mode with visible vest and gun). Off-duty, many agents carry as well (FBI policy allowed off-duty carry of bureau weapon or approved personal weapon). The culture encourages being armed in case something happens – “always an agent.” Some agents might choose a smaller gun off-duty for comfort (e.g., a 5-shot revolver or compact pistol). But officially, they should be armed when performing duties or when they reasonably expect they might need it. When in office at their desk, the gun is often still on them or sometimes tucked in a lockable drawer if they don’t want to sit with it. In court, agents often check guns with court security or leave at office.

They also carry handcuffs, usually on the belt or in a jacket pocket, and a spare magazine or two for the pistol. In the 90s, FBI also started using pepper spray and collapsible batons for less-lethal options – agents might have those in a kit but maybe not always worn unless expected need. On operations, add body armor

(concealable vests under clothing for potentially dangerous situations – many agents wear a Kevlar vest when going to arrest someone, under the shirt or externally if raid jacket), and radios, etc. Day to day in office, though, they don't wear vests or tactical gear – they look like any other professional.

## Firearms Policy and Use-of-Force Culture

**Firearms Quals:** The FBI requires agents to qualify on the range regularly (usually quarterly or semi-annually). So an agent's routine includes going to the range to practice. There is pride in marksmanship – most agents are decent shots; some are exceptional and might be instructors. Agents also do **“judgmental shooting”** training (FATS simulator or live role-play) to practice when to shoot/don't shoot <sup>92</sup> <sup>70</sup> . They are taught, as we covered, only use deadly force if a threat of serious harm <sup>69</sup> <sup>70</sup> . And they internalize it: paperwork and investigation follow every shooting <sup>93</sup> , so no agent wants to discharge their weapon unless absolutely necessary.

So culturally, despite a tough image, agents are often cautious about using force – they know the legal and moral stakes. They also know the saying: *“We don't shoot to wound; we shoot to stop (center mass)”* <sup>71</sup> . This is frequently repeated. They practice double-taps to torso, etc. And they *don't* fire warning shots or shoot at fleeing suspects unless that suspect poses imminent danger (because of rules like Tennessee v. Garner <sup>72</sup> ). If an agent did fire improperly, they could face disciplinary action or even criminal charges, plus civil lawsuits. So the culture is: follow the policy strictly. Most agents go entire careers without firing a shot at a person (though many do at some point, in critical incidents).

**Carrying Off-Duty:** FBI policy doesn't mandate 24/7 carry, but many agents do carry off-duty as they see themselves always an agent. Particularly in a place like Arizona where gun carrying is not unusual, an off-duty agent might have a firearm concealed when out to dinner (likely a smaller one, not the full Glock brick). Some might lock it in glove box if going somewhere sensitive (like to a sports game where you might be searched). This is a personal choice, but the Bureau encourages being prepared to act if an incident arises. Off-duty, they should also carry creds in case they need to identify as FBI in an emergency.

One note: If drinking alcohol, the unwritten rule is you should not carry or be prepared to take law enforcement action because your judgment is impaired. Many agents abide by that – if they go to a bar and plan to drink, they leave the gun locked or with them but vow not to intervene unless life/death extreme (and if possible, they wouldn't drink too much to begin with). The culture values self-discipline.

**Use-of-Force Continuum:** Agents have intermediate options: They can use verbal commands, physical holds, baton, pepper spray, or deadly force as last resort. But FBI agents aren't patrol cops; they seldom have to break up bar fights or such where those come in. It's usually either compliance or a firearm-level threat in federal cases. If a violent struggle happens, they're authorized to fight back with appropriate force. They also are taught some defensive tactics (though FBI DT training back then was not as intensive as say police academy – a few weeks at Quantico and occasional refreshers). In the office, any time force was used, paperwork follows (an FD-302 detailing it, plus internal review if beyond minor). If pepper spray used, that's a report; if baton used and someone injured, that's a report.

**Firearms and Ammo:** In 1997 FBI ammo likely was hollow point rounds (for effectiveness and less over-penetration). The Glock 22 held 15+1 rounds .40 S&W. Agents also could have shotgun or rifle in car trunks if trained – by late 90s, FBI was increasing use of carbines for high risk (especially after 1997 North Hollywood shootout in LA where bank robbers with rifles outgunned police – FBI responded by getting

more long guns to agents). So an agent might sign out an MP5 or M4 from the office gun vault for a raid. Phoenix's FBI SWAT had specialized weapons like MP5s, AR-15s, etc., and standard agents might have access to a Remington 870 shotgun or M16 if qualified.

**Safety Checks:** The culture is to be safe with guns always – keep finger off trigger, etc. An agent who has a negligent discharge (accidental firing) faces embarrassment and discipline. It's hammered in training to avoid that.

## Work Hours and Life

**Hours and Overtime:** Officially, agents had a 40-hour workweek plus availability for emergencies. In 1994, Congress implemented **Law Enforcement Availability Pay (LEAP)** which gives agents +25% salary for the expectation they might work 50+ hour weeks routinely <sup>94</sup>. So by 1997, agents are salaried with that extra pay – no overtime pay per hour, but they are expected to put in the time needed. Practically, this meant many agents worked perhaps 45-50 hours a week normally, and more during big cases. If nothing major is going on, they might keep roughly 9-to-5-ish hours, but if leads or surveillances run late, they stay until done. Weekends, they rotate who's "on-call" (the duty agent) to handle urgent complaints. If something big happens (like a kidnapping), that agent's weekend is gone, they call in team and work around clock.

Agents often joke they work "when needed" – could be all night on a stakeout, then catch sleep in morning and in late to office. Flexibility is part of the deal. In role-play, you could have scenes where the squad is exhausted after a 2-day manhunt, catching a nap at their desks or finally going home at noon after being up all night. Or days where it's lighter – paperwork day where they leave at 5 to see family. But culturally, putting in extra effort is seen as honorable – but also there's an understanding to take care of one's health and family life to avoid burnout.

**Travel:** Agents travel occasionally for cases – e.g., flying to another state to pick up a prisoner or do an out-of-state lead. In 1997, they'd fly armed on planes (with paperwork filed), or drive if nearby. Travel is part of hours – sometimes long drives. They get per diem for travel but not extra pay beyond LEAP.

**Case Ownership and Initiative:** The FBI has a strong sense of "case ownership." If you open a case (case agent), it's *your* case to drive. That means responsibility and credit. If someone else has an idea or lead, they'll pass it to you rather than run it independently (unless you ask them to). Agents don't steal cases from each other; that's a major no-no ethically and career-wise. If one agent is away, another may cover but still acknowledges it's Agent X's case. When promotions or awards come, case achievements matter, so agents are conscious of not stepping on each other's toes. In the Phoenix office, squads might even be a bit competitive (white-collar vs violent crime on stats), but that's friendly for the most part.

Case ownership also means an agent might be protective of their informants. They cultivate informants and don't want others snatching them or over-using them without coordination. FBI policy actually forbids one agent using another's informant without permission.

However, it's a team environment too. Agents constantly assist on each other's cases as "secondary" – helping in surveillances, interviews, etc. They just know who the lead is. Think of it like a detective squad in police: primary detective and partner. In FBI often one case agent and several others assisting as needed.

**Team and Hierarchy Etiquette:** Agents call each other by first names usually, but might address boss as “Boss” or “SAC [Name]” when formal. There’s a respect for chain of command: e.g., if SSA says “drop that lead, focus here,” you do it (unless you strongly object, then you discuss privately, but open insubordination is rare). Agents might gripe about HQ or bureaucracy in private – e.g., “HQ wants another pointless report, sigh” – that’s common culture. But outwardly they comply. FBI culture values obedience but also expects honesty and feedback through proper channels.

**Training and Improvement:** Agents periodically go to refresher training (shooting, legal updates, etc.). By 1997, issues like improved **diversity and sensitivity** training were being introduced (post-Charles P. Smith incident – FBI mid-90s had some discrimination lawsuits, so training on harassment etc. was coming). But overall composition in 90s: still majority male, but increasing female agents (by late 90s ~16% female) and some minority recruitment. The culture was evolving, trying to shed any old-boy image, but some traces remain. As a player, you could incorporate maybe how an older agent might still make a dated joke vs. a younger agent being more modern. But careful, FBI in 90s already was professional; blatant harassment was not tolerated officially (though might still have existed quietly in places).

**Behavior and Discipline: Integrity** is the watchword (it’s literally the “I” in FBI motto Fidelity, Bravery, Integrity). Agents are expected to be honest in all dealings. Lying in an official capacity is a career-ender if discovered. The FBI’s Office of Professional Responsibility (OPR) will investigate internal misconduct. By 1997, after some lab scandals, whistleblower protections were in place <sup>95</sup>. Agents know if they mess up (like a DUI arrest, a lost piece of evidence, or a failed polygraph for an internal matter) it can stall or end their career. They thus tend to be careful. Off-duty, they are held to a higher standard – e.g., an agent getting in a bar fight or caught in an adulterous situation could face discipline for “conduct unbecoming.” The unwritten rule: *Don’t embarrass the Bureau.*

**Firearm off-duty incidents** – say an agent intervenes in a store robbery off-duty and shoots someone. Even if justified, they’ll be scrutinized. But they’d likely be hailed if it saved lives, albeit with full investigation.

**Alcohol and Drugs:** The FBI had (and has) strict drug policies – in 1997, if you had used any illegal drugs recently (within past years) you couldn’t be hired, and obviously usage while an agent is grounds for firing and likely prosecution. Alcohol is the common vice – heavy drinking culture had reduced since the 80s, but some agents still drink socially or more. If someone is an alcoholic, the Bureau might require them to get counseling or they could be dismissed if it affects work. The culture is more professional than say the stereotyped “hard-drinking detective,” at least on the surface.

**Political/Personal Life:** Agents cannot engage in certain political activities (like not allowed to run for partisan office, limited in campaigning). They also have to get approval for outside employment (most don’t have any – the job’s busy enough). Many agents are family people – the job can be tough on family with relocations and hours, but the Bureau tries to be somewhat accommodating (like transfer requests for spousal needs considered).

**Hierarchical Respect:** Addressing superiors: often by title or “sir/ma’am.” A new agent in 1997 would definitely “Yes sir” the SAC or any exec. Among peers, more casual. But even peers have a sense of seniority – a 15-year veteran is often respected by a 2-year junior who might defer to their experience.

**Informality and Humor:** Within the office, agents joke around, use gallows humor to cope with stress (e.g., joking about the absurd criminals they catch or making light of frustrating bureaucracy). They might tease

the “new guy” with some pranks (like sending a rookie to find nonexistent “verbal handcuffs” or such – lighthearted hazing). But overall, they treat each other as brothers and sisters in arms. There’s a sense of fraternity – they socialize outside work, sometimes families get together, etc., especially in a mid-sized division like Phoenix where people know each other well.

**Local Flavor:** Phoenix Division in the 90s might have unique aspects – dealing with desert terrain and border issues. Perhaps agents keep a spare water jug and shovel in trunk (safety in desert). Off-road driving skills were useful for desert chases. Possibly bilingual ability (Spanish) is valued – an agent fluent in Spanish might constantly be tapped to translate for interviews. Also, Phoenix had jurisdiction over Native American reservations, so agents learned cultural sensitivities (like involving tribal police, or understanding that certain protocols exist on reservations for arrests).

**Media and Public:** Agents are not usually authorized to speak to media on record – the FBI has Public Affairs Officers for that and the SAC or ASAC might do pressers. Agents might give background info off record if allowed, but in general rank-and-file are cautious. After a case, some credit might come as a quote in a press release (with SAC approving). Agents are mindful not to seek personal glory via media – that’s frowned upon unless cleared, since it can jeopardize cases or come off as showboating.

**Loyalty and Whistleblowing:** While they value integrity, openly whistleblowing in 90s FBI was rare and seen as betrayal by some colleagues. The culture encourages solving issues internally. But formal channels like OPR exist if an agent sees misconduct. A junior agent would likely consult a mentor or supervisor first if they see something wrong (like evidence being mishandled or prejudice). FBI agents tend to be rule-followers, so actual outright corruption or malfeasance among agents is rare, but if discovered, it’s taken extremely seriously.

**Career Progression:** Many agents aspire to climb the GS (pay grade) ladder or into supervisory roles. Phoenix being a field office not HQ, career advancement might mean transferring to HQ or other divisions after some years. But some prefer to stay agents (field work) rather than management. This can cause a slight culture gap: the ambitious vs the agents who just love investigations. Both are respected in their own way. The ones aiming for promotion might take on high-profile cases or volunteer for programs to stand out.

**Example – Daily Routine:** A day at Phoenix FBI office: 7:30am, agents trickle in. One agent stops by the SAC’s secretary’s desk to pick up mail, wearing slacks and a shoulder holster visible until he puts his suit coat on. Coffee brewing in break room, agents chat about a local news story (maybe a big local crime or sports game). 8:00am, squad meeting: SSA runs through updates, who’s doing what, any new leads or overnight developments. Agents pass around a “lead sheet” listing tasks and who’s assigned. Possibly a quick training reminder (like “guys, qualification at range next week, sign up”). Then everyone heads out to their tasks: some to court, some to the field, some on the phone. One agent might mention, “I have to leave by 3pm for my kid’s school event” – SSA says fine, as long as nothing is on fire. Another agent covers the 3pm informant meet in his stead. There’s flexibility given trust.

At lunchtime, a bunch might go together to a sandwich shop (FBI tends towards group lunches if schedule allows, good bonding). They might gently mock the one agent on a health kick or the one who always orders the greasiest thing. At 5pm, a few head out if day is done, but a couple stay late writing reports. The SSA might also leave around 6 but expects those finishing reports to do so properly even if it means an hour

overtime. If there's a night surveillance, a fresh evening shift comes in or day shift continues with overtime (with LEAP, they don't get extra pay but possibly can take a bit flex time later).

Off duty, maybe Friday happy hour at a bar near the office is common – though they keep it not too wild, as any misbehavior could reflect poorly. Families sometimes get together on weekends – FBI might host a family day or a range day where spouses can try shooting (with supervision). Agents often befriend each other's families due to transfers (they rely on each other for advice when moving, etc.).

**Morale and Ethos:** The mid-late 90s FBI had good morale generally – crime was being tackled, budgets were okay, the big shift to more tech was starting but not yet the chaos it would be in early 2000s. The FBI felt on top of things in many areas (though 9/11 was unforeseen around corner). In Phoenix specifically, maybe agents felt a bit “out west” away from DC – more autonomy to handle things Arizona-way. The SAC likely pushed that Phoenix can handle its own, only calling HQ when needed. The culture in field vs HQ: field is where “real police work” is done, HQ are the “pencil-pushers.” But field knows HQ has power to approve operations and funds, so they show HQ due respect.

Wrap up with a motto or guiding principle: FBI agents truly believed in their mission “*to protect the American people and uphold the Constitution*”<sup>96</sup>. They're proud of being the nation's premier investigative agency. So they adhere to high standards of conduct to maintain that reputation. An agent might quietly mention the motto “*Fidelity, Bravery, Integrity*”<sup>97</sup> to a colleague when facing a tough ethical choice – a reminder of their core values.

## Technology and Resources in 1997

Rewinding to 1997, the FBI's technological landscape looks very different from today's. It was a transitional era – some modern systems were being built, but a lot of old-school methods were still in play. For a role-player, it's important to avoid anachronisms (no modern smartphones, no high-speed internet in the field) and accurately depict the tools an agent had. Let's break down various tech and resources:

### Communications

- **Radios:** FBI agents relied heavily on two-way radios for tactical and team communication. Field agents carried portable radios (walkie-talkie style, often under a jacket with a coiled earpiece up the collar). Cars had more powerful mobile radios installed. In 1997, these were likely analog VHF/UHF channels, possibly with some encryption for sensitive channels. Agents would have specific frequencies for their office/squads, and could also access inter-agency channels if coordinated (there was often a “city PD channel” radio in FBI cars for monitoring locals). Range could be an issue in rural AZ – repeaters and relay through dispatch might be needed. There's no texting or GPS on radios – just voice. So, an agent might radio to the office if out in field to run a license plate (if they didn't have a car terminal).
- **Telephones:** Desk phones and payphones were important. Cell phones existed but were not ubiquitous like today. By '97, many agents did have cell phones (the brick or early flip phones) for work – but not all, sometimes just team leaders. They were used primarily for voice calls, as SMS texting was extremely rudimentary and not commonly used by law enforcement yet. Coverage in rural areas was spotty. Agents still often had pagers (beepers) as backup: the office could send a numeric page (“911” for urgent) and the agent would find a phone to call in. Payphones were

everywhere in 1997; an agent on surveillance might duck to a payphone to call the office or another agent if radio wasn't secure or was out of range.

- **Computers and Email:** This is a big one. The FBI had computers at desks, but they were mostly terminals connected to FBI networks, not modern PCs with internet. The **Automated Case Support (ACS)** system, introduced 1995, was essentially a text-based database for case documents <sup>15</sup>. Agents or support staff would type in case summaries, leads, etc., on a green-screen or basic GUI. It was cumbersome (many agents found it easier to write their reports in WordPerfect and then maybe attach to ACS or print out). Email within FBI existed (on networks like Bureau Electronic Messaging Network), but many agents, especially older ones, preferred phone or in-person. By 1997, some forward-looking ones used email for inter-office communications, but you wouldn't see them checking Outlook on a smartphone (no BlackBerries yet; those came early 2000s). If they had email, it was likely on a desktop only, and not everyone checked it constantly. For urgent comms, a phone call was standard.
- **Teletypes/ECs:** The FBI still called certain electronic messages "teletypes" out of tradition, but these were sent via computerized systems. If Phoenix needed to send an alert or lead to all offices, they'd send a teletype (like a multi-address email, essentially) using standardized format <sup>14</sup>. These would print out in offices or appear on terminal. Big nationwide alerts (e.g., fugitive wanted) would go like this. Fax machines were also used for sharing documents quickly with outside agencies.
- **Satellite or Secure Comms:** Rare for field agents. Maybe an agent on a SWAT sniper team had a secure radio channel. Or if they were coordinating a classified operation, they might use STU (Secure Telephone Unit) landlines for encrypted calls with HQ. But daily, not so much.

## Computers, Databases, and Analysis

- **FBI Case Database (ACS and VAAP):** We covered ACS – an antiquated but essential repository. It allowed searching FBI files by keyword or name. So if an agent got a new subject name, they or an analyst would run an ACS indices search (like the old manual indices but now digital). It wasn't Google – you had to query specific fields. Often name variants had to be tried. But better than paper cards of earlier times. However, many older case files were scanned or summarized only, and some still required requesting paper files from storage.
- **NCIC (National Crime Information Center):** This was (and is) the go-to for criminal records, warrants, stolen property nationwide. Run by the FBI's CJIS division <sup>8</sup> <sup>28</sup>. In 1997, agents would access NCIC via a dedicated terminal or by calling the field office dispatcher to run it for them. NCIC would tell if a person is wanted, if a vehicle is stolen, if a gun is stolen, etc. All major police agencies input data into NCIC. For instance, if an agent pulls over a car, they can radio the plate to FBI or local dispatch to NCIC-check if stolen or associated with felonies.
- **Identification (Fingerprints):** The FBI's fingerprint ID was moving from manual to automated. By '97, the FBI was finalizing IAFIS – a big computerized fingerprint matching system to go live in 1999 <sup>98</sup>. Until then, prints were often still classified by human experts and searched in large databases that took days/weeks unless it was a high-priority and they did expedited manual search. Field offices could ink suspects on an **FD-249 fingerprint card** <sup>73</sup> and overnight it to FBI CJIS for identification. Some large offices had LiveScan machines (digital print capture) just coming into use. But it wasn't instant as it became post-99 (minutes). In 97, it might be same-day or next-day if urgent, or longer for routine.
- **CODIS (Combined DNA Index System):** 1997 is early days of DNA database. The FBI was rolling out CODIS to states – but it's not fully populated yet. If you got a DNA profile, you might be able to search if the state lab or FBI has it on file from another case or convicted offender, but many states were just starting to collect felon DNA. So DNA matching, while possible in lab-to-lab, might not yield

as much as today. If two cases had DNA, they could match if same unknown person, but identifying that person needed them to be in the small existing database.

- **NIBIN (Ballistics database):** Mentioned in forensics, the National Integrated Ballistic Information Network, partly run by ATF and FBI, was nascent <sup>79</sup>. It could compare bullet and casing marks. In 97, it was in early deployment – Phoenix might or might not have had the system; if not, they'd send evidence to a regional ATF lab.
- **Financial Databases:** FinCEN, as mentioned, tracked large cash transactions and suspicious activity reports (SARs) from banks. Agents could request FinCEN checks to see if their suspect had any flagged transactions. Also, credit reports – agents could pull credit histories (with subpoena or letterhead request) to find addresses, loans, etc. They also used TRW or similar address databases (early people-finders). Much of this required contacting HQ or other agencies – not just a quick web lookup.
- **Documents and Writing:** Most agents wrote reports in **WordPerfect** (which was DOJ standard in 90s) on desktop computers, then printed them. Some had access to scan docs, but scanning was not widespread like now. Photos from film had to be developed (FBI had photo labs or used commercial dev with chain-of-custody procedures). So inserting photos in reports wasn't digital, they'd physically attach or include photo prints in files. PowerPoint or overhead transparencies might be used for presentations (especially for prosecutors in court visuals).
- **Translation Tech:** If needing to translate tapes or documents, FBI had linguists or would contract out. No Google Translate; and things like intercepting a phone call in another language meant having bilingual agents or later analysis.

## Surveillance Tech

- **Vehicles:** Standard unmarked sedans (Ford Tauruses, Chevy Caprices, etc.), often local-looking cars. Maybe SUVs for rough terrain (a Ford Bronco or Suburban in AZ for desert use). No fancy James Bond mods beyond hidden radios. Some cars might have a secure radio that can cross between FBI freq and local.
- **Airplanes:** FBI had some small planes (Cessnas) for surveillance. Often with FLIR (forward-looking infrared) or cameras to track at night. In 97, FLIR existed and FBI used it in some cases (notably Ruby Ridge and others earlier). So if doing a big surveillance, they might call in an FBI plane from say the Tucson RA or nearby (or DEA's plane, as DEA had many).
- **Tracking devices:** Primitive by modern standards. They had “beepers” – battery-powered radio transmitters attached to cars that emitted a signal the agents could follow with a directional receiver. They required a court order (like a warrant) to install and monitor, even back then (though law was gray until 2012 Supreme Court, FBI still usually got a warrant or at least a consent from owner). These devices weren't GPS – they just told you signal strength/direction. Range not huge, maybe a mile or two. And you had to be relatively in vicinity with the receiver. There were early GPS trackers in late 90s, but not widespread in FBI yet – those came in 2000s more. So chase by tail was still the norm.
- **Cameras:** Mostly film cameras for surveillance photography. Agents used SLR cameras with zoom lenses. Polaroid cameras for quick snapshots at crime scenes for immediate use. Some digital cameras emerged mid-90s but resolution was low and not broadly used by FBI till early 2000s. Video cameras – handheld camcorders using Hi8 or VHS-C tapes were used for stakeouts from cars (a long lens poking out a tiny gap in window). Also, **pole cameras** as mentioned, which might transmit video to a nearby van or record to a VCR. Those were used in certain stakeouts (like watching a gang hangout).

- **Night Vision:** FBI had Starlight scopes or night-vision goggles for low-light. Mostly SWAT or specialized surveillance teams would use them. They were bulky but functional for observing in near darkness. Thermal imagers were rarer and more expensive (FBI HRT had them; field might borrow).
- **Audio Surveillance/Wiretaps:**
- **Body Wires:** Equipping informants or undercover agents with hidden microphones/transmitters was common <sup>42</sup>. Those transmit to a recorder or listening post nearby. The tech in 97: small mic and transmitter (perhaps disguised as a pager or in clothing), with agents recording on a cassette or reel system in a car or van within a few blocks (range limited, though some used relays). This requires one-party consent (which they had via the wired person's consent) and often an internal approval (documented on forms like FD-473 for consensual monitor) <sup>99</sup>. Quality varied; walls and interference could cause gaps. They'd have spare batteries, etc.
- **Phone Taps:** For criminal cases, getting a Title III wiretap order was possible but you needed heavy probable cause and approvals up to DOJ. If granted, FBI techs physically installed a wiretap on the phone line at the central office (with phone company help). By 97, many lines were digital or cellular, so intercepts required help from providers. For cell phones, it was early – analog cell phones could be picked up by scanners illegally, but FBI would do it via carriers legally. They record calls on high-speed tape decks and have agents monitor live (with minimize rules – they stop listening when irrelevant or privileged talk). So a wire room might have several machines and translators if needed, with agents working shifts to listen and spot crucial info.
- **Room Bugs:** Planting a microphone in someone's office or home also needs a court order (Title III for listening, or a FISA order if national security). FBI sometimes did that – small mic with transmitter hidden in a wall or item, transmitting to a recorder nearby. Range and battery life limited, or sometimes wired to power source. Risky to plant (need a surreptitious entry team).
- **Pen Registers:** To get phone dialing records (numbers called, times) in real-time, FBI used pen register devices at phone company, with a court order but lower standard than wiretap. Useful to see a suspect's contacts. Today that's metadata, but then it was a physical device or a feed from phone company. There's an FD form to log usage of pen register <sup>100</sup>.

## Office Tech and Support

- **Forensic Lab Access:** Phoenix division would send evidence to FBI Laboratory in Quantico for advanced analysis (DNA, specialized fingerprints, etc.) <sup>74</sup>. Locally, they might have an evidence team that can do basics (latent fingerprint dusting, photo lab to enlarge pictures, etc.). The turnaround from FBI lab could be weeks unless expedited. Agents sometimes got impatient waiting for results from Quantico, especially DNA which in 97 could take months unless priority.
- **Automated Name Checks:** The FBI also maintained other indices like the Terrorist Screening Center (pre-9/11 it was less formal, but they had watchlist indices for known terrorists) and criminal indexes. Agents could send a memo to HQ to run a thorough name check which would search everything – that was standard for vetting informants or suspects comprehensively. Takes time though.
- **Translation and Decoding:** If the case involved coded messages or foreign language, they'd employ linguists or code-breakers from FBI or NSA depending on nature. For example, in Phoenix maybe not common except Spanish which local agents often handled. If they intercepted communications in say Russian (like Russian OC case), they'd get a Russian-speaking agent or go to the Language Services Division. Not instant – transcripts could take days per tape.
- **Vehicles and Airplanes Fleet:** The FBI had motor pools. Agents could request specialty vehicles (e.g., a van with hidden compartments for stakeout, or a fake utility truck). They also had access to some aircraft – maybe Phoenix had a plane or two assigned for surveillance and transport. For long distances, they'd just fly commercial armed or with prisoner (with Marshals help for prisoner).

- **Databases – External:** FBI could query state DMV for license info (in 97 not online instantly; they might call DPS or use NLETS – National Law Enforcement Telecom System – a network connecting state databases). They could also get criminal history from state systems. Many of these were text-based queries via NCIC or NLETS terminals.

**No Smartphones or Modern Gizmos:** Emphasize: no GPS in car, no Google, no social media to monitor (1997 internet had early forums and websites, but criminals weren't on Facebook – if anything maybe hacking boards or obscure internet chat, which only specialized computer crime squads looked at). If an agent wanted to surveil communications, maybe they look at pager records (pagers often stored last few numbers, or phone company could provide logs of pages).

**Office Computers:** They likely used early Windows (Windows 95 came out in '95). Some offices may still have Windows 3.1 or OS/2 systems for certain apps. WordPerfect was DOS or Windows version. Some agents still might not be computer-savvy – they'd dictate reports into a tape and give to a secretary to type (dictation was still used by some older agents in 90s). Yes, the clerical support workforce was bigger then to handle paperwork.

**Example – Using Tech in a Case:** You have a suspect with a cell phone – you subpoena billing records from the phone company (no real-time cell pinging tech like today without special equipment). The records arrive by fax or mail – reams of numbers. You or an analyst manually analyze them to find patterns (e.g., frequently called numbers). Maybe you plug data into a simple database or spreadsheet – data analysis software was rudimentary or done by HQ specialists. If urgent, you could get a pen register on the cell to see incoming/outgoing numbers live. If you need to track his location by cell – in 97, cell site tracking was very approximate (just see which tower a call hit, which covers many square miles). No GPS in phone yet. So physical surveillance was key.

If you have a computer to search at a suspect's home, in 1997 you don't have a dedicated "computer crimes agent" in every office (though every office was starting to have someone who knew computers). You might copy the hard drive (if you have tools) or just seize the whole computer (tower, etc.) and send to FBI lab. The lab would use forensic software to image and analyze it (like early EnCase or just manual file browsing). It could take weeks to get results like recover deleted files.

**One futuristic thing:** FBI had begun the **Integrated Automated Fingerprint ID System (IAFIS)** project to drastically speed up fingerprint matches <sup>101</sup>. They hyped how in 1999 it'd cut matching to minutes (which it did, eventually). So an agent in 97 might mention "we'll submit these prints to the new IAFIS system coming online – hopefully get a quick hit" though if timeline is strictly 97, IAFIS was not yet live. More likely, they just send to the lab's AFIS pilot, which might compare to state AFIS. Many states had their own AFIS by late 90s, which could be searched relatively quickly at least for state prints.

**Vehicles & Logistics:** FBI field offices had budgets for renting vehicles under cover (like to pose as a plumber van, they might rent one or own one rebranded). They also had evidence response trucks for major evidence collection (like a van with equipment). If moving large items, they might use box trucks.

**Budget constraints:** In 97, budget was decent (post-OKC and WTC93 attacks gave FBI more resources). But still, agents can't waste money – they must account for every expense like informant payments, travel receipts, etc. If they need expensive gear, they have to request it. For example, maybe a new digital recorder – they might have to justify it to HQ or get from a bigger office.

**Conclusion on Tech:** The FBI in 1997 was a mix of old and new – pen and paper still in hand for notes, but a desktop computer on the desk; radios crackling, but also some early email; fingerprint cards in ink, but a looming high-tech system being installed in Clarksburg WV <sup>13</sup> . The agent of that era had to be adaptable, using cutting-edge when available but also able to do legwork the old-fashioned way.

For your role-play, it means the agent character might run to the office to send a teletype rather than firing off a quick text; they might develop film in a darkroom rather than scrolling through digital pics; and they rely on personal skill and informants as much as fancy databases to get intel. That grounded realism will set the scene firmly in the late 90s.

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**Conclusion:** This sourcebook has journeyed through the world of an FBI field agent in 1997 – from the bureaucratic structure they navigate, through the gritty tradecraft on the streets, to the halls of justice in the courtroom, and the everyday professional life that binds it all together. Throughout, we've highlighted historically accurate practices and terminology, cross-referencing specialized topics (forensics, legal statutes, etc.) available in other guides for deeper exploration.

By absorbing these insights, a role-player can confidently step into the shoes of a 90s FBI special agent: speaking the lingo ("Put out a BOLO", "Run it through NCIC", "Set up a PI (preliminary investigation)"), carrying themselves with the G-man blend of cool and courtesy, and applying the methodical yet resourceful approach that characterizes the Bureau.

The late 90s were a fascinating time for the FBI – traditional investigation methods were enhanced by emerging tech, the range of crimes spanned from mobsters to new cyber threats, and the culture was that of a venerable agency adapting to a new era while holding tight to its core values of Fidelity, Bravery, Integrity <sup>96</sup> . Portray your agent with realism and respect for these elements, and you'll bring to life a convincing and engaging character ready to tackle whatever challenges your story presents, be it a Phoenix bank heist or a cross-country manhunt.

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<sup>71</sup> <sup>72</sup> <sup>76</sup> <sup>79</sup> <sup>82</sup> <sup>83</sup> <sup>85</sup> <sup>86</sup> <sup>87</sup> <sup>88</sup> <sup>89</sup> <sup>90</sup> <sup>91</sup> <sup>92</sup> <sup>93</sup> FBI Phoenix Field Office Agent Legal Handbook (1997).pdf

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